双语译林

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小王子

The Little Prince

Antoine de Saint-Exupéry
[法国]圣埃克苏佩里 著
林珍妮 中译
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导读

张媛媛

圣埃克苏佩里(1900—1944),法国里昂人,作家。他首先是一个出色的飞行员,其次才是一个作家。1921 年到 1923 年,他在法国空军中服役,先是后备飞行员,后成为民航驾驶员,参加了开辟法国——非洲——南美洲国际航线的工作。他在各种艰苦条件下都飞过,还曾经因为飞机失事被困雪山七天。平常他抓紧时间在各种艰苦的条件下写作,成就斐然。

1939 年,德国法西斯入侵法国。尽管圣埃克苏佩里曾多次负伤,被医生认为不能再入伍,但他坚决要求,终于被获准编入 2/33 空军侦察大队。1940 年法国溃败,他所在的部队损失惨重,被调往阿尔及尔。他复员后流亡美国,在美国期间,他继续写作,发表了《战机飞行员》、《给一个人质的信》以及童话《小王子》。尽管身体状况不太理想,年龄也偏大,但他还是继续请缨为受法西斯蹂躏的法国作战。1943 年,他来到了法国在北非阿尔及尔的抗战基地。上级只让他执行五次飞行任务,他却主动要求增加到八次。1944 年 7 月 31 日上午,他出航执行第八次任务,从此再也没有回来。牺牲时,年仅四十四岁。

2000 年,一个渔夫打捞到一条手链,上面有圣埃克苏佩里的名

字和送他手链的出版商的名字。在法国一处海岸，人们又找到了他所驾驶的飞机的残片。多年来人们一直传说，圣埃克苏佩里像小王子一样回到了 B612 星球，这当然只是出自人们的美好想象，现实是，他确实是像一个英雄一样为国捐躯了。

法国人一直把圣埃克苏佩里当做民族英雄，在他逝世五十周年之际把他的肖像印在五十法郎的票面上。而对世界各地的小读者来说，他的盛名来自《小王子》。这篇 20 世纪流传最广的童话，从 1943 年发表以来，已被译成一百多种文字，还被拍成电影、搬上舞台、灌成唱片。据说《小王子》在全世界的销量仅次于《圣经》，当然，这个说法未必准确，但读者多年来的热爱和追捧却是确凿无疑的。

那么，《小王子》究竟是一本怎样的书呢？

首先，《小王子》是一个童话，但不是一个普通意义上的童话。它充满了对人类生活状态的思考，是一个所谓“哲理童话”。但它没有讲任何大道理。它甚至没有“娓娓道来”地讲任何道理。它与说教无关。一切都蕴藏在这个如诗如画的故事里，蕴藏在星星、沙漠和清泉里，蕴藏在小王子银铃般的笑声里。它就像真理本身那么朴素动人。合上书，你会觉得甜美而忧伤，也许还会有点想哭呢。有人说这是一个沉重的童话。也许是吧。深者见其深，浅者见其浅，这正是一切好故事的品质。

其次，《小王子》语言非常简单优美，不仅能让小孩子听懂，读懂，也很适合大人阅读，帮助大人重拾好的语言习惯——大人的语言世界常常是混乱和不洁净的。

说到《小王子》的成书背景，我们可以从三个方面来理解：

一是圣埃克苏佩里的飞行员生活。

他曾经因飞机故障降落在撒哈拉沙漠，书中提到的茫茫沙漠、恐慌、口渴，都是他亲身体验过的，所以才会写得这么真实。

当一个人总是从三万英尺的高空俯瞰芸芸众生，他对这个世界自然有独特的思考。他的视野是如此广阔，相比之下人的狗苟蝇营却显得那样渺小。头上是浩瀚的星空，心中是澎湃的感情。

二是当时的时代背景。

二战进行到最激烈的时候，作者被迫流亡美国。这场不仅破坏人们生活，也摧毁人们很多美好信念的战争，对他的震撼是可想而知的。他重新思考人存在的价值，思考人对物质的追求和被蒙蔽的心灵。

三是他自己的生活。

那朵惹人喜爱却令人心碎的玫瑰，其实是作家深爱的妻子的一个投影。当然，蕴涵了这么深的哲理，这朵花就不能被单纯看做作家的妻子了。但他告诫我们：爱的执着，是来自于一次次的浇水、呵护和倾听。“正因为你为你的玫瑰花费了时间，才使她变得这么重要。”

在行动上，在思想上，在语言上，圣埃克苏佩里都是一个巨人。正因为如此，他才能写出这么质朴又意味深长的作品。

通过这个童话，圣埃克苏佩里带着我们感受生活的美好，接触生活的本质，而不是像小王子看到的那些“大人”，为权势、虚荣、职务、学问之类表面的东西忙忙碌碌。那个自以为很有权威，其实却成了对权威的追求的牺牲品的国王；那个要求别人向他不断脱帽和鼓掌的自负的人；那个为喝酒感到惭愧，为忘记惭愧而拼命喝酒的家伙；热

衷于统计星星数目的商人；自己从不出门的地理学家；拘泥于职责的劳累的点灯人……他们都有个共同的特点，就是把真正美好的东西忽略掉了。

小王子说："使沙漠如此美丽的，是它在某处藏着一眼泉水。"

也许我们可以把这句话简单理解为：使生活如此美丽的，是我们藏起来的真诚和童心。

《小王子》陪伴很多孩子成长，成为他们人生中一个美好的印记；也影响了许多成年人，触动他们深藏的童心。

小王子说："这就是我的秘密。其实很简单，我们用心才看清楚，用眼睛是看不见本质的东西的。"

对于广大读者来说，这也是指出了读这本书的一个秘密。用眼睛，也要用心去看。

还有，我们都愿意相信，小王子还活着，和他的玫瑰、他的小羊幸福地生活在一起，笑起来声音像银铃一样。

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小王子

献给列翁·维尔特

请孩子们原谅我把这本书献给一位大人。我有这样做的充分理由：这位大人是我最要好的朋友。我还有另一个理由：这位大人什么都懂，他完全能理解写给孩子们阅读的书籍。我还有第三个理由：这位大人住在法国，正在忍饥挨饿，他需要别人的安慰。要是你们认为这些理由还不充分，那我就把这本书献给小时候的他吧——所有的大人都经历过童年。（但很少有大人记得自己曾是孩子。）因此，我把我的献词改为：

献给从前那个小男孩列翁·维尔特。

1

六岁那一年，我在一本描写原始森林的书里看见一幅扣人心弦的图画。那本书的书名叫做《丛林奇遇记》。图中画的是正在吞吃野兽的蟒蛇。下面是这幅画的复印件。

书中说："蟒蛇囫囵吞下猎物，肚子撑得它不能动弹，要躺六个月才能把猎物消化掉。"

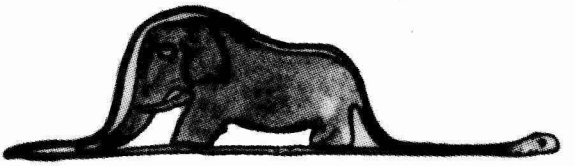
从此，我对丛林的种种奇事产生了无穷尽的遐想。我也用彩色铅

笔绘下我的第一幅画。我称它为一号画。一号画如下：

我把我的杰作拿给大人看，还问他们，我的画是否吓坏了他们。

他们回答我说："一顶帽子有什么可怕的？"

我画的不是一顶帽子，而是一条正在消化大象的蟒蛇啊。我又画了一张画，画的是蟒蛇和它肚子里的大象，好让大人看懂我的画。他们总是需要我们给他们解释的。我的二号画如下：



大人们劝我，别画这些肚子没打开或打开了的蟒蛇了，把心思放到地理、历史、算术、语法上去吧。就这样，我在六岁这一年放弃了画家的光辉生涯。一号画、二号画的失败令我垂头丧气。大人们老是需要孩子们费尽唇舌，给他们再三解释，不然就一窍不通，真把我们累得够呛。

我只好选择另一门职业。我学会了驾驶飞机，几乎跑遍了世界各地。地理确实帮了我的大忙。在空中，我一眼就能认出中国和亚利桑那[①]，这样的本领很管用——如果夜航时迷了路。

① 美国的一个州。

我一生与许多重要人物打过交道，我在大人当中生活了很长时间，我仔细地观察过他们，然而我对他们的看法没有多大的改善。

我始终保留着我的一号画。遇到一个我认为略为懂事的大人，我就用这幅画做试验，看他是否真的懂事，但他们总是这样回答我："这是一顶帽子。"听了这样的话，我就不再与他们谈蟒蛇、原始森林、星星了。我谈他们能理解的事情，例如桥牌啦，高尔夫球啦，政治啦，领带啦。大人们便很满意，以为他们认识了一个通情达理、善解人意的人。

2

从此我孤独地生活着，没有一个可以推心置腹的朋友。这种状况一直延续至六年前。六年前，我的飞机出了故障，发动机里的某个部件被撞坏了，我被迫在撒哈拉沙漠降落。身边没有机械师，没有一个乘客，我只好勉为其难，自己动手，试着修理部件。我带的水仅够喝一个星期，能否修好飞机，关系到我的生死存亡了。

第一夜，我在远离人烟、千里之遥的沙漠上睡觉。比起那些乘着木排，在茫茫大洋中挣扎漂浮的遇险者，我更显得孤独无助。

朝霞初露的时候，一个细细的奇妙的声音把我唤醒。你不难想象我当时有多惊讶了。这细细的奇妙的声音说：

“劳驾……请你给我画一只绵羊吧!”

“你说什么?”

“给我画一只绵羊……”

我像遭了雷击，一跃而起。我使劲揉我的眼睛，仔细地看了看，只见一个很奇特的小小的人儿，他正在那儿注视我呢。下面就是以后我给他画的最为成功的一幅肖像画。

当然，它没有他本人可爱俊美，这可不能怪我，该怪大人，是他们

在我六岁那年葬送了我的画家生涯。除了画打开肚子和没打开肚子的蟒蛇之外，我没有画过一张画。

我大吃一惊，眼睛瞪得溜圆，看着这位突然出现的人儿。你们可别忘了，这儿是远离人烟、千里之遥的地方啊。我的这个小人儿一点不像迷了路，也不像是累死、饿死、渴死、吓死的鬼魂。他一点不像迷失于沙漠中的孩子，不像远离人烟、千里之遥的孩子。

我终于能够张口说话了，我问他：

“……你在这儿干什么？”

他不慌不忙地重述他的要求，像说一件很严肃的事情：

“请你给我画一只绵羊……”

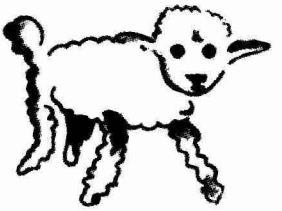
当神秘的东西使得你心惊肉跳的时候，你不敢不听他的命令。虽然，身处远离人烟的荒漠，面临死亡的威胁，叫人画画的要求又未免荒唐，我还是从口袋里掏出一张纸和一支钢笔。我忽然记起，除了钻研地理、历史、算术、语法，我没有画过画，便没好气地冲小人儿说，我不会画画。

他说：“不要紧，给我画一只绵羊吧。”

我从没画过绵羊，只画过那两张画。我就给他画了其中的一张，就是没有打开肚子的蟒蛇。我吓了一跳，我听见小人儿说：

“不!不!我不要象在蟒蛇的肚子里。蟒蛇太可怕，象太占地方。我的家地方不大。我要绵羊，给我画一只绵羊吧。”

我便画了一只羊。



他仔细看看，然后说：

“不好!这是一只患了重病的羊。给我画另一只吧。”

我又画了一只羊。

我的朋友露出亲切可爱的微笑，并没有责怪我的意思，他说：

“你瞧瞧，这不是小羊，是公羊，它长着角哩。”

我又画了一张。

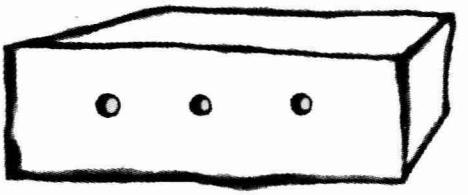
这一张画和前面两张一样，遭到了他的拒绝：

“这只太老了，我要一只能活很久的绵羊。”

我急于着手拆卸我的发动机，失去了耐性。我胡乱涂了下面这幅画。

而且我冲他说：

“这是一只箱子，你要的绵羊在里面。”



然而我惊讶地看到，我的这位小法官竟眉开眼笑：

“我要的正是这样的箱子!这只绵羊要很多草吗?”

“为什么你提这个问题?”

“因为我的家太小啦……”

“肯定够了。我给你的是一只很小很小的绵羊。”

他低头看画。

“没有这个这么小吧……咦!它睡熟了……”

我就这样认识了小王子。

3

过了好久好久，我才弄明白他是打哪儿来的。

小王子向我提了许多问题，却从不理会我对他提的问题。我从他无意中吐出的片言只语里，逐渐知道了他的来历。

例如，当他第一次看见我的飞机的时候(我不愿画飞机，太复杂了)，就问我：

“这是什么玩意儿呀?”

“它不是玩意儿，它会飞。这是飞机，是我的飞机。”

我挺自豪地告诉他我会飞。他嚷起来：

“怎么?你是从天上掉下来的吗?”

“是的。”我并没有吹嘘的意思。

“啊!这就奇了……”

小王子发出清脆悦耳的笑声，他这一笑可惹恼了我。我不喜欢别人对我的不幸打哈哈。然后他又说：

“这么说，你也是从天上下来的!你住在哪一个星球上?”

这句话犹如一道亮光，让我马上瞥见了他突然出现的秘密。我以突袭的方式问他：

“你是从另一个星球来的?”

他不答。他看着我的飞机,轻轻地点头:

“从你乘的这玩意儿来看,你确实不可能来自很远的地方……”

他陷入沉思。过了很久,他从口袋里掏出我画的绵羊,低头凝视他的宝贝。

你们不难想象,听了他那句无意透露的“其他星球”的话后,我会怎样惊讶吧。我竭力从中探听他的来历:

“我的小人儿，你从哪儿来？你的家在哪儿？你要把你的绵羊牵到哪儿去？”

他默默不答。然后才说：

“你给了我一个箱子，太好了。夜里可以给绵羊做屋子了。”

“是呀，如果你乖，我还要给你一根绳子，白天给你拴羊用。我还要给你一根拴羊的桩。”

我的建议显然惹恼了小王子：

“拴住它？亏你想得出这样的主意！”

“你不拴住它，它会乱跑的呀，会走失的呀。”

我的朋友发出清脆的笑声：

“你以为它会跑到哪儿去呢？”

“到处乱跑呗，朝前跑呗……”

小王子告诉我：

“这倒不成问题，我的家小得很呢！”

他的神色略带忧伤，说：

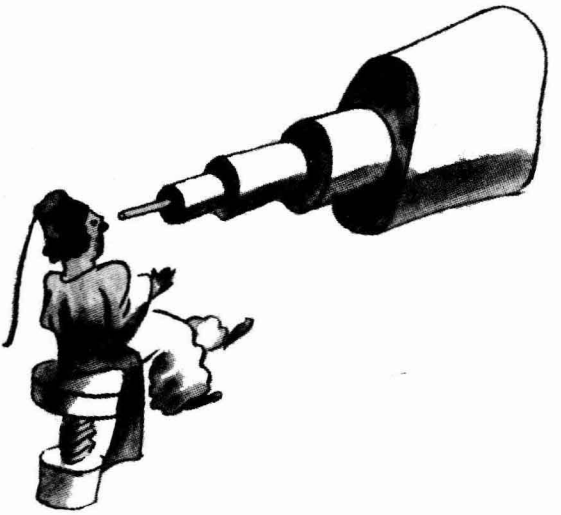
“朝前跑，也跑不了多远……”

4

就这样，我知道了第二件很重要的事情：他打那儿来的星球比一幢房子大不了多少！

我并不因此大惊小怪。

我知道，除了起了名字的大星球，如地球、木星、火星、金星，还有成千上万的星球。有些星球小到连望远镜都难以观测。天文学家发现



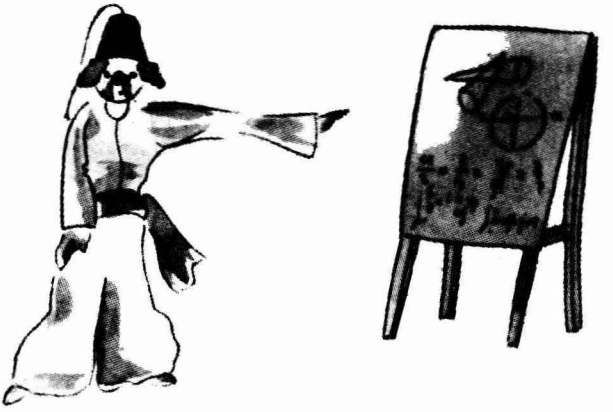
一颗星，就用号码给它命名，例如叫它“小行星 325 号”。

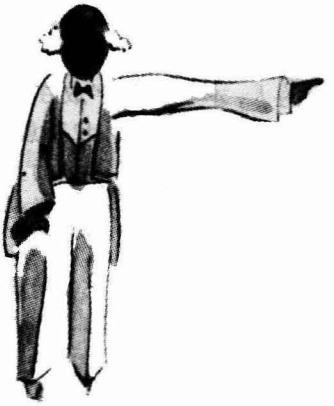
我有充分的证据认为小王子打那儿来的星球就是 B612 号小行星。这颗小行星仅仅在一九〇九年被一位土耳其天文学家用望远镜看见过一回。

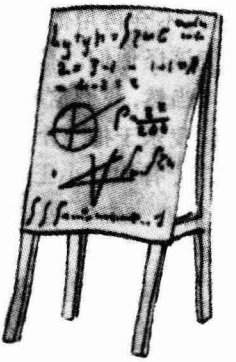
在国际天文会议上，他为他的发现作了雄辩的论证，但没有人相信他的报告。因为他穿的是土耳其人的服装。大人们就这个德行：以衣冠取人。

幸好，为了维护 B612 小行星的声誉，土耳其独裁者颁布了一条法令，命令百姓改穿欧式服装，否则处以死刑。一九二〇年，这位土耳其天文学家身穿一套极考究的西服，再一次在国际会议上作了论证。这一回，他得到了大家的认可。

我对你们详细报告发现小行星 B612 的这些细节，把它的号码告诉你们，都是由于那些大人们的缘故。因为大人们对数字情有独钟。如果你对他们介绍一个新朋友，他们从不打听他的基本情况，他们从







不会问你:“他的嗓子怎么样?他喜欢玩什么游戏?他是否采集蝴蝶标本?”而是问:“他几岁了?有多少个兄弟?体重多少?他的父亲挣多少钱?”他们认为了解了这些情况,就了解了一个人。

如果你告诉大人:“我看见一幢漂亮的红砖房子,窗前摆着天竺葵,鸽子在屋顶栖息……”他们便无法想象这是一幢怎样的房子。你必须对他们说:“我看见一幢值十万法郎的房子!”他们就会惊叹:“多漂亮的房子啊!”

所以,如果你对他们说:“这世上确实存在一位王子,证据就是他可爱俊美,脸带笑容,他要一只绵羊。一个人要一只绵羊,就是他存在的证明。”他们会不以为然,耸耸肩,以为你是不懂事的孩子!但如果你对他们说:“他打那儿来的星球是小行星 B612。”他们就深信不疑了,就不会用没完没了的问题烦你了。他们就这副德行。我们不要责怪埋怨他们,孩子对大人应当尽量地宽容。

当然,我们是理解生活的人,我们才不会把数字放在眼里呢!我

喜欢以讲童话的方式讲这个故事。我喜欢这样讲：

“从前有个小王子，他住在小行星里。这颗行星比他自己大不了多少。他需要一个朋友。”对于理解生活的人，这样讲似乎要真实得多。

我不喜欢别人漫不经心地读我的书。提起这些往事，我还挺伤心的。我的朋友牵着他的羊走了六年了。我在这儿讲述他的故事，是为了不忘记他。忘了朋友是可悲的。并不是每个人都有朋友的。也许有一天我也像大人那样，除了数字，对别的东西都失去兴趣。为了这个缘故，我买了一盒颜料和几支铅笔。到了我这个年龄才重拾画笔是困难的。而且，除了在六岁那年画过一条打开肚子的蟒蛇和一条没打开肚子的蟒蛇之外，我没画过别的画。当然，我可以画最逼真的人像画。但能否成功，我把握不大。这一幅画得可以，另一幅却画得不像。对他的个儿高矮，我也记得不太真切。这幅把他画得太高，另一幅把他画得太矮。该给他的衣服抹什么颜色，我也犹豫不决。我在画纸上抹来抹去，画了张约莫相似的肖像，但某些重要部位也许弄错了。对这一点，你们一定要谅解。我的朋友从不向我解释，大概他以为我和他一样；可是我呢，很遗憾，我不能透过箱子看到里面的绵羊。也许我有点像大人了。我大概老了。

5

每一天，我都从他那儿获得一些有关星球、启程、旅行的知识。这些知识是逐渐得到的，只要想到什么问题就提什么问题。第三天，我就是这样了解到有关猴面包树的事情的。

这一回还真亏了绵羊。因为小王子突然对一件事产生了极大的怀疑，突然问我：

“羊吃灌木，这是真的吗?”

“是呀，是真的呀。”

“啊，那我很高兴。”

我不明白，羊吃灌木为什么这么重要。小王子又问：

“这么说，它们也吃猴面包树啦?”

我提醒小王子，猴面包树不是灌木丛，而是像教堂一样巍峨高大的树。即使他弄一群大象来，它们也啃不完一棵猴面包树。

想到一群象啃猴面包树的情景，小王子忍不住笑了：

“那它们非得叠罗汉了……”

他很机灵，指出：

“猴面包树的树苗挺小的呢!”

“你说得对!可是你为什么希望你的绵羊吃猴面包树苗呢?”

他说:“嘿!那还用说吗!”似乎这是再明白不过的事情。而要我自己想明白这个问题,我确实要绞尽脑汁了。

是的,小王子的星球和其他星球一样,长着益草,也长着毒草,因此也就有了益草的种子和毒草的种子。但种子是看不见的,它们沉埋在土地深处,直至其中一颗突然苏醒……它伸伸懒腰,羞羞答答,向着太阳伸出一株青嫩可爱、娇小玲珑、不伤人的幼苗来。倘若它是萝卜或玫瑰的幼苗,我们可以任由它茁壮成长;倘若它是有毒的植物,一经认出,我们就必须马上拔除。小王子的星球上埋着可怕的种子……这就是猴面包树的种子,星球的土壤饱受其害,不及时动手除掉它们,你就永远别想摆脱它们的侵害。它的树身枝叶占据整个星

球，如果星球小，而猴面包树过多，就会撑破星球。

后来小王子对我说："人早上梳洗之后，一定要小心清理地球，要经常督促自己，要养成良好的习惯。猴面包树的苗儿与玫瑰花的苗儿长得极相似，把它们区别开来之后，就要经常督促自己拔除猴面包树苗。这活儿单调乏味，但也挺容易干。"

有一天，他建议我用心画一幅猴面包树的画，要让我们那儿的孩子牢牢记住它。他对我说："有朝一日他们外出旅行，这幅画就派上用场了。有些时候，耽搁了的工夫造不成多大的恶果，然而对猴面包树的危害却不能轻视。我知道，有一颗星球上住着一个懒人，他忽略了剔除三棵猴面包树苗的事儿……"

在小王子的指点下，我画了这个星球。我素来不喜欢装腔作势，

摆出一副道学家的面孔训人，但许多人对猴面包树的危害认识不足，在小行星上迷路的人遇到的风险又那么大，我不能不一反平日矜持的常态，大声疾呼："孩子们，当心猴面包树啊！"为了向朋友们发出警告，让他们提防早已威胁我们的危险——而他们和我一样，对这样的危险一无所知——我对这幅画下足了功夫。提醒大家警惕危险，是我义不容辞的责任。

也许你们看了这幅画后会纳闷："为什么他在这本书里画的其他画没有这张猴面包树的画雄壮，有气势？"我的回答很简单：我尽了力去画其他的画，但心有余而力不足。而画猴面包树的时候，为急迫的需要所激励，我的画便超出了原有的水平。

6

啊!小王子!我就是这样逐渐了解到,你过着并不顺心愉快的生活。长期以来,你唯一的消遣就是观赏夕阳西下的美景。第四天早晨,我又知道了这一件事。你对我说:

“我喜欢夕阳。我们去看日落的壮观吧……”

“可是要等啊……”

“等什么?”

“等太阳下山的时刻呀。”

你露出惊讶的神气,然后又自觉可笑,说道:

“我老以为我是在自己家里呢!”

这话说得不错。大家都知道,在美国,太阳正在天空的当中,而这时在法国,太阳已经西下。若能在一分钟之内赶到法国,就可以观看落日的壮景,遗憾的是法国离得太远了。但是,在你那小小的星球上,你只要把椅子挪几步就能看到日落了。什么时候要看夕晖都能看得到……

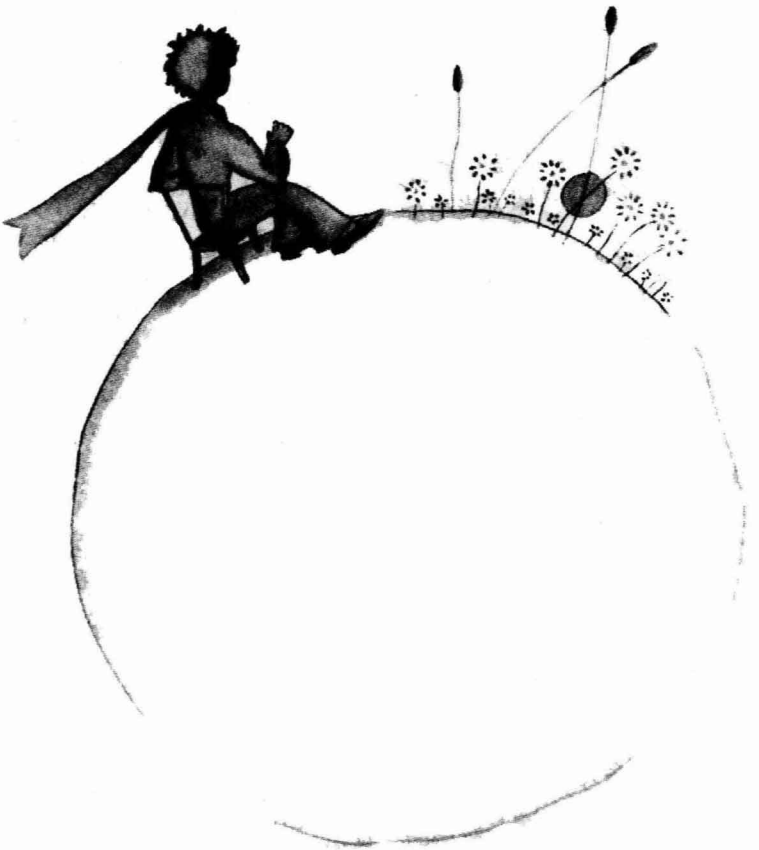
“有一天,我看了四十四次太阳下山!”

过了一会儿,你又说:

“你知道……一个人愁闷的时候，都爱看西下的夕阳……”

“看了四十四次太阳西下的那一天，你的心情差得很吧？”

小王子没有答话。



7

第五天，仍然是多亏了那只绵羊，小王子生活中的秘密才被泄露了出来。他似乎对一个问题反复思考了许久，然后开门见山，直截了当地突然问我：

“绵羊吃灌木，它也吃花吗？”

“绵羊遇见什么吃什么。”

“带刺的花也吃？”

“吃的。带刺的花也吃。”

“那刺还有什么作用呢？”

我不知道刺还有什么作用。当时我正忙于把发动机上拧得过紧的螺栓弄下来。看来故障极其严重，我正在犯愁呢。最让我担心的，是饮用水已经所剩不多了。

“那刺还有什么作用呢？”

小王子一旦提出疑问，就要寻根究底，追问个没完，绝不会中途而废。我正被螺栓闹得心烦意乱，便顺口答道：“刺不起作用，都是因为花儿心眼太坏！”

“哦？”

沉默了一会儿，他悻悻地说：

“我不信你说的话!花儿弱不禁风，花儿天真无邪，她们自顾不暇呢。她们身上长了刺，是为了给自己壮胆，为了保护自己……”

我不说话。这时我的念头是：“如果这颗螺栓拧不下来，我就用锤子把它砸了。”

小王子打断我的思路：

“你相信，你，相信花……”

“别烦我了!别烦我了!我什么也不信!我不过在信口开河啊。我，我在忙正经事呢。”

他瞪着我，愣住了。

“你在忙正经事!”

他看见我手攥锤子，两手油污，俯身对着一件他认为很丑的物件。

“你说话的时候像个大人!”

听了这话，我有点难为情。然而他又毫不留情地讲了一句：

“你是非不分……你混淆黑白!”

他真的气坏了。一头金发在风中乱摇。

“我知道一颗行星，上面有一位红脸先生。他从未嗅过一朵花。他从未观赏过一颗星星。他从未爱过一个人。他什么事也没干过，只会做算术中的加法。他整天就像你一样，反复地唠叨：‘我是个正经人!我是正经人!’真是自命不凡、神气活现!可他不是人，是蘑菇!”

“是什么?”

“是蘑菇!”

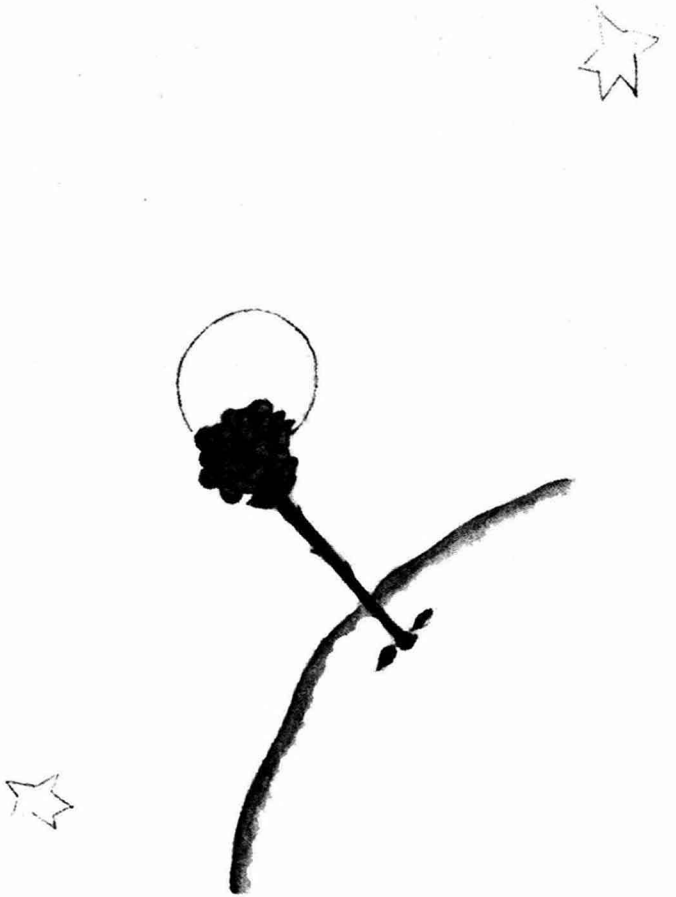
小王子气得脸色发白。

“几百万年以来，花儿都长着刺；几百万年以来，羊也在吃花。难道我想知道，花儿为什么憋足了劲长没用的刺，这是不正经的事吗？这不比红脸胖子的加法更正经、更重要吗？要是我认识的世界上的一朵独一无二的花，她哪儿也不去，就爱长在我的星球上，可是却在某天早晨，被小绵羊一不留神咬死了，难道这样的事也不重要吗？”

他的脸由白转红，然后说：

“要是有个人爱上了一朵花，这朵花不长在亿万颗星球上，只长在他的星球上，而他只要仰望星空，想到‘我的花儿就在那儿……’，心就陶醉在幸福里，羊却吃了他心爱的花——这对他而言，简直是整个星空都黯淡无光了，难道这样的事还不重要吗？”

他说不出话来，突然嚎啕大哭。夜幕降临，我扔下手里的工具，顾不得锤子、螺栓、干渴、死亡了。在一颗星球上，在我的行星地球上，有一个小王子需要安慰！我把他搂进怀里，轻柔地摇着他。我抚慰他：“你爱的那朵花不会有危险的……我给你的绵羊画一个口罩……我给你的花儿画一副铠甲……我……”我也不知道我还说了什么话，只觉得自己笨嘴笨舌，不懂得该怎样安慰他，打动他……眼泪的王国太神秘了。



8

我很快就对这朵花有了更深的了解。小王子生活的星球上长着很朴素的单瓣花，她们一点儿也不占地方，也不扰人，在草地上朝开暮落。而这朵花的种子不知道是从哪儿来的。小王子密切注视着她的与众不同的嫩枝。她很可能是新品种的猴面包树苗呢。然而枝条很快

就停止伸展，竟开始结花蕾。小王子看着硕大的花苞，预感到她会绽放出奇异的花朵。然而花儿躲在绿莹莹的屋子里精心打扮。她仔细挑选颜色，慢条斯理地穿衣，一片片地搭配她的花瓣。她不肯像虞美人那样，皱巴巴地就往外跑，就亮相。她要容光焕发地见人。唉!不错，她就是朵极爱俏的花儿。她神秘兮兮地梳妆打扮了好几天，终于在一天早晨，在太阳出来的那一刻，她露脸亮相了。

精心打扮了几天，算准了出场的时间，她却打着哈欠说：

“唉!我刚刚睡醒呢……请你原谅……我的妆还零乱呢……”

小王子忍不住赞叹：

“您真美啊!”

“是吗，”花儿柔声说，“我和太阳同时诞生……”

小王子看准她并非谦恭的女子，不过，她确实美丽动人!

“是吃早点的时候了吧。”很快她又说，“劳驾您给我……”

小王子为自己的疏忽而感到羞惭，赶紧找了一壶清水，侍候花儿用餐。

不久，她爱慕虚荣的性情开始折磨他。例如，有一天，她对小王子说到她身上长的四根刺的用途。她说：

“这儿也许有老虎吧，老虎的爪子锋利得很呢!”

“我的星球上没有老虎。再说，老虎不吃草。”小王子表示异议。

“我可不是草。”花儿柔声说。

“对不起……”

“我一点也不畏惧老虎，但我讨厌风。您没有屏风吗?”

“你居然讨厌风啊……这可不好。”小王子对她有了看法，“这朵花倒很复杂……”

“晚上您用罩子把我罩起来吧。您这儿太冷，位置不好。我来的那个地方……”

她住了口。来这儿的时候她还是一颗种子呢，怎么可能了解别的地方呢。她撒的谎幼稚可笑，让人一下子就能识破。她觉得丢脸，便咳嗽了两三声，想把过错推到小王子身上去：

“我要的屏风呢？……”

“我正要去找屏风，是您和我说话的呀！”

她又故意咳嗽，存心让他内疚不安。

小王子很怜爱她，但她的做作令他生疑。他是个做事一丝不苟的人，常把无关紧要的闲话当真，难免招来不少麻烦。

有一天，他向我倾诉他的心事：“我本不该听信她的话的。永远也别信花儿讲的话。她们的作用就是供人观赏，供人嗅闻。我的花熏香了我的星球，但我不懂得为此高兴。她说的老虎爪子的话，本来应该

打动我的心，我却生了她的气。”

他还说：

“那时我真是不懂事。要对一个人下定论，不应听其言，而应观其行。她芬芳馥郁，赏心悦目，我不应抛下她一走了之!我不理解她那不聪明的谎言饱含的深情。花儿是缺点不少，但优点也很多的矛盾的东西!那时我年纪太轻，不懂得珍惜她，爱她。”

9

我估计他是趁候鸟迁徙时出走的。出走的那天早晨，他认真收拾整理他的星球，仔细疏通火山口。他有两座活火山，热早饭挺方便的。他还有一座死火山。可是正如他说的："日后的事很难说！"谁知道死火山会不会变活呢？所以他也疏通死火山。经过疏通，火山里的火焰缓缓燃烧，火山就不会喷发。火山喷发的道理与炉火一样。我们这些人太渺小，没有疏通火山的能力，所以火山才给我们造成很多麻烦。

小王子闷闷地拔除了最后几棵猴面包树苗。他知道自己不会再回来了。那天早晨，他觉得所有的家务活干起来都挺亲切的。最后一次给花儿浇水，准备给她盖上罩子，他竟觉得他想哭。

他对花儿说："别了。"

她不做声。

"别了。"他又说。

花儿咳嗽，可不是因为着了凉。

她终于对他说："我以前真傻，请你原谅。好好地享受生活吧，愿你幸福。"

她并没有责备他的意思。他觉得挺意外。

他不知所措地站在那儿，高举着罩子。他不理解她的脉脉深情。

“是的，我爱你，”花儿对他说，“你丝毫没察觉到我对你的爱，这是我的错。如今说也没用了。你和我一样傻。好好地享受生活吧，愿你幸福……你把这罩子放一边去吧，我不需要它。”

“可是风……”

“我并非如此地弱不禁风……清新的夜风对我的健康有好处，我是一朵花儿嘛。”

“可是动物……”

“如果我想认识蝴蝶，就必须能承受两三条毛虫。这似乎是很美的事。要不，谁会看望我呢？你呢，又快离我而去了。我一点不畏惧大的动物，我有爪子呀。”

她天真地伸出她的四根刺。然后又说：

“别婆婆妈妈、磨磨蹭蹭的了，闹得人心乱。你既已下了决心，那就走吧。”

她不愿让小王子看见她哭。她是一朵多么骄傲的花儿哟……

10

他居住的星球位于小行星325号、326号、327号、328号、329号、330号所在的地区。于是他决定首先拜访它们，在那儿找事干，并增长见识。

325号行星上住着一位国王。他穿着镶有紫红色袖口和领口的白鼬皮衣服，坐在式样简单然而威严的宝座上。

看见小王子，国王大声嚷：

“哈!来了一个老百姓。”

小王子心想：

“他从未见过我，怎么认得出我呢?”

他不知道，国王们把世界看得很简单，他们以为普天下的人都是他的百姓。

国王为终于成为另一个人的国王而自豪。他对小王子说：“过来，让我好好地瞧瞧你。”

小王子用眼睛搜寻可坐之处，可是行星被国王豪华的鼬皮塞满了，他只好站着，因为累了，他打了个哈欠。

“在国王面前打哈欠，违反礼节，我不准你打哈欠。”国王说道。

小王子抱歉地说:“我不是有意的。我长途跋涉,没有睡眠……”

“既然如此,”国王对他说,“我命令你打哈欠。我已经多年没看见别人打哈欠了。依我看,打哈欠挺好玩的。快!打吧!这是命令。”

“您的命令让我害怕……我打不了……”小王子涨红了脸。

“嗯,嗯,”国王说,“那么我……我命令你一会儿打,一会儿不打……”

显然,挨了小王子的冲撞,他有点气恼,话也说不流利了。

国王最关心的是别人尊重他的权威,他不允许别人违抗他的命令,他是一个典型的专制君王,但他毕竟是个善良之辈,下达的命令都合乎情理。

“要是我向一个将军下令,要他变成海鸟,将军是不愿服从的。这样,错不在将军,错在我身上。”他说,口齿很伶俐。

“我可以坐下来吗?”小王子怯怯地问。

“我命令你坐下。”国王说,他威风凛凛地一挥白鼬皮皇袍的下摆。

小王子有个问题弄不明白:这颗星球小得惊人,国王统治什么?

“陛下……”他说,“请原谅我向您提个问题……”

“我命令你向我提问题……”国王急忙说。

“陛下……您统治什么?”

“统治一切!”

国王指指他的星球,其他星球,所有的星球。

“所有这一切?”小王子问。

“所有这一切……”国王答道。

因为他不但是个专制君主，还是宇宙之王。

“所有的星星都听命于您吗?”

“当然啦，”国王说，“它们令出即行。我不能容忍无纪律的行为。”

小王子既赞叹又羡慕国王的权威。如果他也掌握这样的权力，一天之内他就可以不止观赏四十四次，而是观赏七十二次，甚至一百次，或两百次日落，还不用挪动椅子!想到被他遗弃的小行星，他有点伤感惆怅。他壮壮胆，请求国王开恩：

“我想观看夕阳西下……求您开恩……命令太阳下去吧……”

“如果我命令将军像蝴蝶那样，在花间飞来飞去，或命令他写一部悲剧，或变成海鸟，如果将军接到命令后不愿执行，你说是他的错还是我的错?”

“那是您的错。”小王子不假思索便脱口而出。

“你说得对，不能强人所难。”国王说，“权威首先必须建筑在理性上。如果你命令你的人民跳海，他们定会造反。我有命令百姓服从的权利，那是因为我的命令符合情理。”

“那么，我要求的日落呢?”小王子问道。一旦提出一个问题，他是不会中途而废的。

“你会看到你要求的日落的，我会发布命令。要科学管理一个国家，下命令应等时机成熟。”

“什么时候时机才成熟呢?”小王子问。

“嗯，嗯，首先我要查看大皇历。嗯，嗯，要等到……今晚……七时四十分左右……左右……你会看到他们怎样执行我的命令。”

小王子打了个哈欠。他感到惋惜，因为他的要求泡汤了。再说，他

已经有点儿腻烦了。

“我在这儿没事可干了,”他对国王说,“我要告辞了!”

“你别走。”国王说,拥有一个百姓,对他来说是一件值得自豪的事,“别走,我任命你为部长!”

“哪个部的部长?”

“……司法部。”

“可这儿没人可审呀!”

“这可就难说了,”国王说,“我还没视察过我的王国呢。我上了年纪,这儿又没有停马车的地方,走路又太累了。”

“啊,我已经看过了。”小王子俯身朝星球的另一端又瞟了一眼,“那儿也没一个人……”

“你就审你自己吧,”国王说,“这是最难办的事。审自己比审别人难得多。你若能审自己,你就是真正的聪明人。”

“我嘛,”小王子说,“无论在什么地方我都能审自己,无须住在这儿。”

“嗯,嗯,我知道。”国王说,“在我的星球的某一处,有一只老耗子。我在夜里听到的。你可以审这只老耗子。隔一段时间判它一次死刑。这样,它的死活就由你的裁判决定了。但你每一次都要免除它的死罪,你要悠着点,因为就只有这一个犯人了。”

“我可不喜欢判人死刑。”小王子说,“我看我该走了。”

“别走。”国王说。

小王子已经做好走的准备,但他不愿伤老国王的心,他对老国王说:“如果陛下您希望令出即行,您可以向我下达合理的命令。例如

说，可以命令我在一分钟之内离开。我认为时机已经成熟……”

国王一言不发。小王子犹豫片刻，然后叹口气，抬腿走了。

国王急忙大叫：“我封你为大使。”

他摆出威风凛凛的神气。

小王子一面赶路，一面自言自语：

“大人们真怪。”

11

第二颗星球住着一个爱慕虚荣的人。

“啊!啊!崇拜我的人访问我啦!”看见小王子,这位爱慕虚荣的人打老远就高声喊。

爱慕虚荣的人以为别人都崇拜他。

“您好。”小王子说,“您的帽子真怪。”

“这顶帽子是用来敬礼的,” 爱慕虚荣的人说,“有人向我欢呼的时候,我就用它敬礼。可惜这儿没一个人来。”

“您说什么?”小王子听不懂他的话。

“请你鼓掌吧。”爱慕虚荣的人建议。

小王子依言鼓掌。爱慕虚荣的人举起帽子,态度谦恭地行礼。

“这比拜访国王有趣多了。”小王子暗自想。他又一次拍巴掌。爱慕虚荣的人又举帽子行礼。

反复操练了五分钟之后,小王子厌倦了这个单调的游戏。

“该怎样做才能让您放下帽子?”小王子问。

爱慕虚荣的人听不见这句话。爱慕虚荣的人只听得见赞扬声。

“你对我真的崇拜到了五体投地?”他问小王子。

“什么叫做‘崇拜’?”

“‘崇拜’就是承认我是星球上最帅、衣着最讲究、最富有、最聪明的人。”

“在你的星球上只有你一个人啊!”

“你就让我享受被人崇拜的快乐吧,仍然崇拜我吧!”

“我崇拜你,”小王子耸耸肩,“这有什么值得你快乐的呢?”

小王子走了。

“大人们确实怪得出奇。”小王子一边赶路一边对自己说。

12

下一颗星球住着一个酒鬼。这次访问时间不长，但小王子极为不快。

“你在干什么?”小王子看见酒鬼在喝闷酒，面前摆着一大堆空瓶子和装满了酒的瓶子，就这样问他。

“我在喝酒呀。”酒鬼闷闷不乐地回答。

“你为什么喝酒呢?”小王子问他。

“为了忘记呗。”酒鬼答。

“为了忘记什么?”小王子有点可怜他，又问。

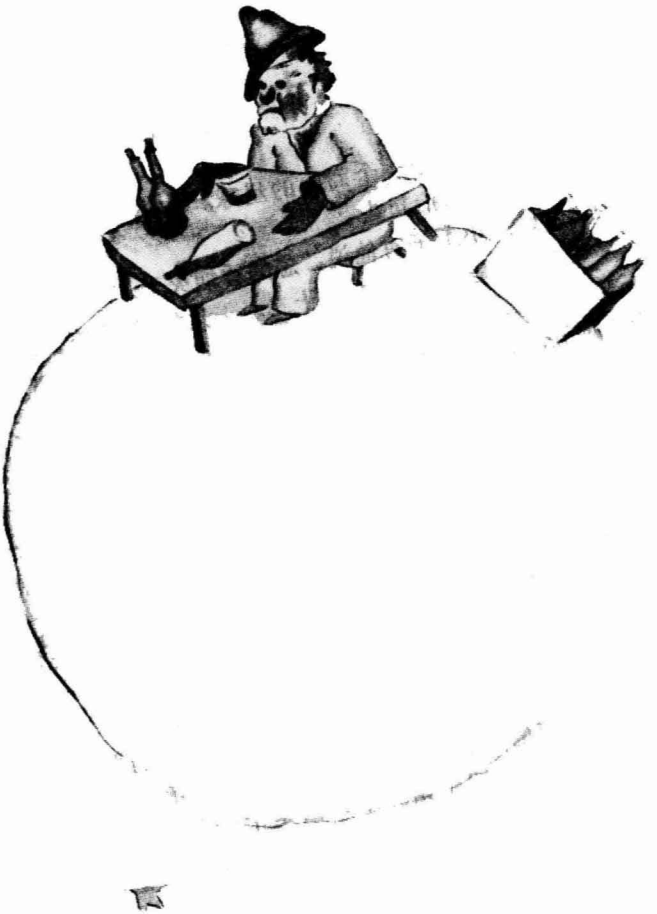
“为了忘记羞愧呗。”酒鬼低着头，老老实实地承认。

“为了什么事羞愧呢?”小王子打算帮助他，又问。

“我为喝酒羞愧!”酒鬼讲完后，闭了嘴巴不再讲话。

小王子大惑不解。小王子走了。

“大人们真是没法理解。”小王子一边赶路一边想。



13

第四颗星球是商人的星球。小王子到来的时候，商人正埋头忙碌，头也没抬起来。

“您好!”小王子说，“您的香烟已经熄灭了。”

“三加二等于五，五加七等于十二，十二加三等于十五，你好。十五加七等于二十二，二十二加六等于二十八，我没时间点烟。二十六加五等于三十一。嗬!一共是五亿零一百六十二万两千七百三十一。”

“五亿个什么?”

“什么?你还在这儿?五亿零一百……我也闹糊涂了……我的活太忙了!我是个正经人，不爱讲废话!二加五等于七……”

“五亿零一百万个什么?”小王子还在追问，他一旦提出问题，绝不中途而废。

商人抬起头：

“我住在这个星球上已经五十四年了，只受过三次干扰。第一次干扰发生在二十二年前，鬼知道从哪儿掉下一个愣头青，发出的声音大得吓人，弄得我的加法出了四个错；第二次干扰发生在十一年前，我患了关节炎，我缺乏体育锻炼，我没时间闲逛，我是个正经人；第

三次……就是这一次!我刚好算到五亿零一百万个……”

“五亿零一百万个什么?”

商人知道他休想安宁了:

“五亿零一百万个小东西,有时在天上看得到的小东西。”

“苍蝇吗?”

“不是,是闪闪发亮的小东西。”

“蜜蜂吗?”

“不是,是金色的小东西,能教闲得发慌的人发痴做梦的小东西,可我是正经人,我没时间遐想做梦。”

“啊!是满天的繁星吗?”

“就是这个。满天的星星。”

“你要五亿多颗星星做什么?”

“是五亿零一百六十二万两千七百三十一颗。我是个一丝不苟的人,我务求精确。”

“你要星星干什么?”

“我要它们干什么?”

“是呀。”

“没什么用。我拥有它们。”

“你拥有星星?”

“是呀。”

“我见过一个国王,他……”

“国王不是‘拥有’,他是‘统治’。大不相同。”

“你拥有星星又怎么样呢?”

“拥有了星星,我就成了大富翁呗。”

“成了富翁有什么好处?”

“如果又有人发现了新的星星,我就把它们买下来呀。”

小王子心想:“这个人的推理方法有点像我见过的那个酒鬼。”

他仍然提出问题:

“怎样才能拥有星星?”

商人烦了,没好气地反问:

“你说,这满天的星星属于谁?”

“我不知道。它们不属于任何人。”

“那么它们属于我。因为我是第一个想到要拥有它们的人。”

“光是想就行了吗?”

“那还用说吗?你发现一颗没有主人的钻石,这颗钻石就归你了。你发现一个不属于任何人的岛,这岛就是你的了。你头一个想出一个主意,你就可以申请专利,这个主意就是你的了。而我呢,我拥有星星,因为在我之前没有一个人想过要拥有星星。”

“这倒是真的。”小王子想,“你要星星做什么用?”

“我管理它们。我数它们,一次又一次地数它们。”商人说,“这是件困难的事,但我是个正经人!”

小王子对这个回答还不满意:

“我若拥有一条围巾,我可以把它围在脖子上带走;我若拥有一朵花,我可以把它摘下带走。可你摘不下星星呀!”

“我不能摘星星,但我能把它们存入银行。”

“这是怎么回事?”

“我在一张小纸条上写上我的星星的数目,然后把它锁进抽屉里。”

“就这样?”

“这就行啦!”

小王子想:“这倒是挺好玩的,还挺有诗意的呢,但算不上是严肃正经的事儿。”

对“严肃正经的事儿”,小王子的看法与大人的看法极不相同。

小王子说:“我呢,我拥有一朵花,我就天天给它浇水;我拥有三座火山,我就每个星期给它们疏通清理。我也疏通死火山,因为日后的事难说。我能做对火山、对花有益的事,才叫做拥有它们。但你却不

给星星做有益的事。”

商人张口结舌，找不到话回答。小王子掉头走了。

“大人们真是怪得没法说。”小王子一边赶路一边嘀咕这一句话。

14

第五颗星球稀奇古怪，它是熠熠繁星中最小的一颗，它仅能容纳一盏路灯和一个点灯人。小王子怎么想都想不明白，这颗位于太空中不起眼的星球，既没有房屋，又没有居民，这路灯和点灯人有何用途。他想："这个点灯人也许古怪，然而他不会比国王、爱慕虚荣的人、商人、酒鬼更荒谬吧，至少他干的工作还有意义。他点亮路灯，如同给太空增添一颗星星，或一朵鲜花；他熄灭路灯，就是让花儿和星星休息睡眠。这活儿充满诗意，既然充满诗意，那就是有益的工作。"

他走近星球，毕恭毕敬地向点灯人行礼：

"你好。你刚才为什么把灯灭了？"

"这是规定。"点灯人答道，"早上好。"

"什么规定？"

"熄灯的规定。晚上好。"

他点上灯。

"你怎么又把灯点着了？"

"这是规定。"点灯人说。

"我不明白。"小王子说。

“用不着明白，”点灯人说，“规定就是规定。早上好。”

他灭掉路灯。

然后他用红方格手帕抹抹额头。

“这活儿可把我累苦了。从前的规定还合乎情理，早上熄灯，晚上点灯。熄灯之后休息，点灯之后睡觉……”

“现在的规定改了？”

“规定倒没有改，”点灯人说，“倒霉就倒霉在这儿！行星一年转得比一年快，而规定却没有改变！”

“这是怎么回事？”

“现在它一分钟转一次，我连一秒钟的休息时间都没有。每分钟要点亮、熄灭一次灯火！”

“这怎么可能呢？你这儿一分钟就是一天？”

“怎么不可能？”点灯人说，“我们已经聊了一个月了。”

“一个月？”

“是的，三十分钟，就是三十天！晚上好。”

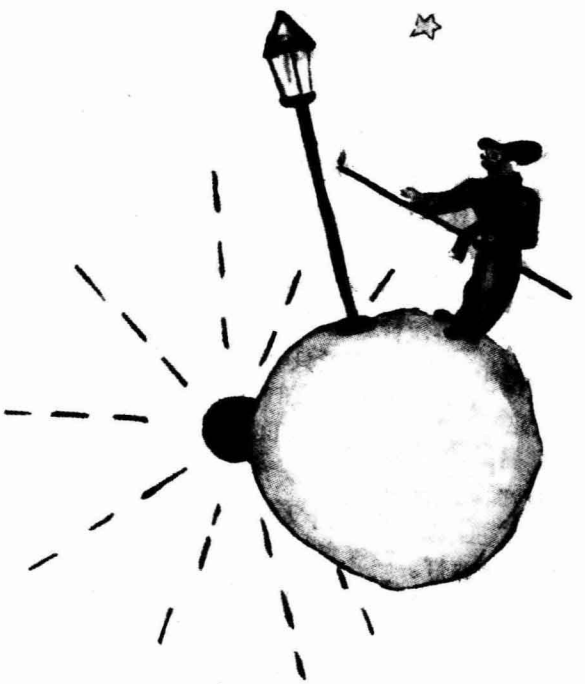
点灯人又点亮了路灯。

小王子看着他，小王子喜欢这个一丝不苟、按章办事的点灯人。他记起自己以前必须挪动椅子才能看到日落的情景。他很愿意帮助他的朋友。

“你知道吗……我有个办法，你什么时候想休息就可以休息……”

“我一直想找个办法呢。”点灯人说。

有个办法既能按章办事又能偷懒就好了。



小王子继续说道：

“你的星球这么小，走三步就绕了一个圈。你只要放慢脚步，太阳就老在你的头顶上。你想休息的时候，你就往前走……你的白天要多长有多长。”

“这个办法解决不了我多大的问题，”点灯人说，“我平生喜欢的就是睡觉。”

“那你就太不走运了。”小王子说。

“我真的不走运。”点灯人说，“早上好!”他又灭了路灯。

小王子一面赶路一面想：“这个人会被其他人瞧不起的。会被国王、爱慕虚荣的人、酒鬼、商人瞧不起。可是他是唯一的我不觉得可笑的人，也许因为他没有光顾自己吧!”

他惋惜地叹口气，又想：

“这个人本来是唯一可做我的朋友的人，但他的星球实在太小了，搁不下两个人……”

小王子不敢承认，他对这颗星球颇有好感的原因是，它得天独厚，二十四小时之内就可以观看一千四百四十次日落。

15

第六颗星球比刚才那颗大十倍。星球上住着一位老先生，正在撰写大部头著作。看见小王子，他大声嚷：

“嗬!来了一个勘探人员!”

小王子有点气喘，坐在桌子上。他赶了大老远的路呢!

“你从哪儿来?”老先生问他。

“这是本什么巨著?”小王子问，“您在这儿干什么?”

“我是地理学家。”老先生说。

“什么叫‘地理学家’?”

“地理学家是学者，知道哪儿有大海、江河、城市、山脉、沙漠。”

“这倒挺有趣的。”小王子说，“总算是真正的职业!”他环顾地理学家的行星。他从未见过这样豪华的行星。

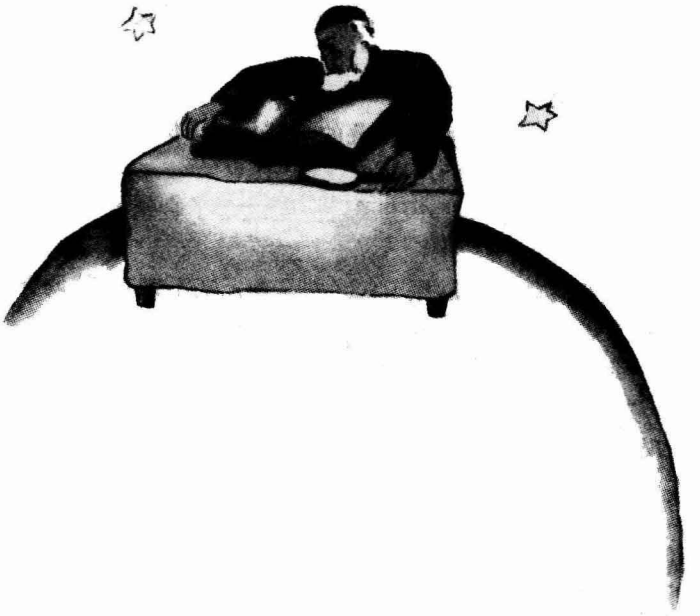
“您的星球真美。这儿有大洋吗?”

“我不可能知道这事。”地理学家说。

“啊(小王子有点失望)!有山脉吗?”

“我不可能知道。”地理学家说。

“有城市、河流、沙漠吗?”



“我也不可能知道。”地理学家说。

“可你是地理学家啊!”

“不错,” 地理学家说,“但我不是勘探人员。我这儿很缺勘探人员。计算城市、江河、山脉、大海、大洋、沙漠的数目,不是地理学家干的事。地理学家太重要了,没有工夫四处闲逛。他必须寸步不离办公室。他在办公室接见勘探人员,询问他们,记下他们的回忆。勘探人员引起了地理学家的兴趣,地理学家就要调查这位勘探人员的品质。”

“为什么?”

“一个撒谎的勘探人员会给地理学家的书带来灾难, 酒喝得太

多的也不行。”

“为什么?”

“酒鬼看的东西是重叠的，地理学家就会在有一座山的地方记下两座山。”

小王子说:“我认识一个人,他会成为糟糕的勘探员。”

“很可能。勘探人员的品质不错,我就调查他的发现。”

“你亲自去实地调查吗?”

“不,那太复杂了。我要求勘探人员提供证据。比如说,他发现了一座大山,我就要求他带大石来。”

地理学家突然兴奋起来:

“你呢,你是从远方来的!你是勘探队员!你给我描写你的星球吧!”

地理学家打开他的登记册,削尖铅笔。他先用铅笔记下勘探人员的口述。勘探人员提供证据后,再用钢笔誊写。

“请谈吧!”地理学家说。

“啊!我们那儿,可没意思了,”小王子说,“它才一点大,我有三座火山:两座活火山,一座死火山,可谁知道以后会有什么变化呢。”

“以后的事谁知道呢。”地理学家说。

“我还有一朵花。”

“我们不记录花的。”地理学家说。

“为什么不记录花呢?它是最美的东西!”

“因为它‘昙花一现’。”

“什么叫做‘昙花一现’?”

“地理书是一切书籍中最珍贵的书籍，从不会过时。山移位、海洋干枯都是极少发生的事。我们写的是永恒不变的东西。”

“可是死火山也会复苏。”小王子打断他的话，“什么叫做‘昙花一现’？”

“火山死与不死，在我们看来都是一回事。”地理学家说，“我们重视的是山，山不会改变。”

“什么叫做‘昙花一现’？”小王子继续追问。他素来如此，一旦提出一个问题，绝不肯放弃。

“‘昙花一现’的意思就是‘面临很快消失的危险’。”

“我的花儿也有很快消失的危险吗？”

“当然。”

“我的花会‘昙花一现’，”小王子想，“而她只有四根刺保护自己，应付这个世界！我却抛弃了她，让她孤苦伶仃地待在我家！”

他头一次体会到悔恨的感觉。然而他还是鼓起勇气问：

“您能否指点我，我该去哪儿访问？”

“到地球上去吧，”地理学家说，“它非常有名……”

小王子走了，一路上都在思念他的花儿。

16

第七颗星球就是地球。

地球可不是等闲之辈!地球上有一百一十一位国王(我当然没有忘记算上黑人国王)、七千位地理学家、九十万个商人、七百五十万个酒鬼、三亿一千一百万个爱慕虚荣的人,也就是说,约莫有二十亿个大人。

为了让你们对地球的面积大小有个具体形象的概念,我给你们打个比方。我告诉你们,世界上还没有人发明电的时候,六大洲需要维持一支由四十六万两千五百一十一个点灯人组成的真正大军。从稍远处眺望这支大军,真是蔚为壮观。点灯人的动作犹如芭蕾舞演员的动作:整齐划一,井然有序。首先上场的是新西兰、澳大利亚的点灯人,他们点亮路灯后就去睡觉。接着加入舞蹈行列的是中国和西伯利亚的点灯人,然后他们也隐没于后台。然后轮到俄罗斯和印度的点灯人,接着是非洲和欧洲的,然后是南美洲、北美洲。这支大军的进场顺序从不错乱,真是让人叹为观止。

唯有北极点灯人和他的南极同行,过着悠闲懒散的生活。北极和南极各自仅有一盏灯,他们一年只点两次灯。

17

好出风头、喜欢卖弄聪明的人，多少会讲几句大话，吹点牛皮。我给你们介绍点灯人的时候，也不太老实。我也许让不了解我们星球的人产生误解，造成错觉。人在地球上占的位置微乎其微。倘若让散居在地球上的二十亿人口集中在一起开大会，他们可以松快地站在二十英里长二十英里宽的广场上。可以把人类堆在太平洋最小的岛屿上。

。

当然，大人们不会相信这些话。他们以为自己占了很大的位置，自以为自己像猴面包树那么庞大。那你就建议他们算一算。他们不是喜欢数字吗？他们会高兴的。但我劝你们别多此一举了，挺麻烦的，毫无用处的。相信我的话吧。

小王子来到地球后，看不见一个人影，不由心里纳闷。他担心走错了路，到了别的星球了。这时，他看见沙地上有一个月白色的圆环在蠕动。

“晚安!”小王子随口说。

“晚安。”蛇说。

“这儿是什么星球?”小王子问。

“是地球,非洲。”蛇回答说。

“哦?……地球上没人吗?”

“这儿是沙漠,沙漠里是没有人烟的,地球很大。”蛇说。

小王子坐在一块石头上,抬头看天空:

“我在想,星星发亮是否为了让每个人有一天能找到自己的星星。你看我的星球,它正好在我的头顶上……可它多么地遥远!”

“它真美。”蛇说,“你来这儿干什么?”

“我和一朵花赌气闹别扭呢。”小王子说。

“哦!”蛇说。

他们都缄口不言了。

“人在哪儿呢?”小王子终于开口说话,“待在沙漠有点孤独……”

“跟人在一起也孤独。”蛇说。

小王子久久凝视着它。

“你是奇特的动物,”小王子终于说道,“你像一根指头般细……”

“可我比国王的指头强大得多。”蛇说。

小王子微微一笑。

“你没有那么强大吧……你连爪子都没有……你连走路都不会……”

“船能送你走远路,可我能送你走更远的路。”

它盘着小王子的脚踝,像一只金镯子。

“我碰到谁，就能把他送回他来的地方，”蛇还说，“但你纯洁，你是从星球上来的……”

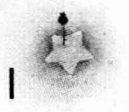
小王子默默无言。

“我同情你，在这花岗岩构成的地球上，你这么弱小。如果你有朝一日思念你的星球，我可以帮助你。我可以……”

“啊！我完全明白你的意思，”小王子说，“但你的话为什么句句都像谜似的？”

“我能解一切谜。”蛇说。

他们都不讲话了。



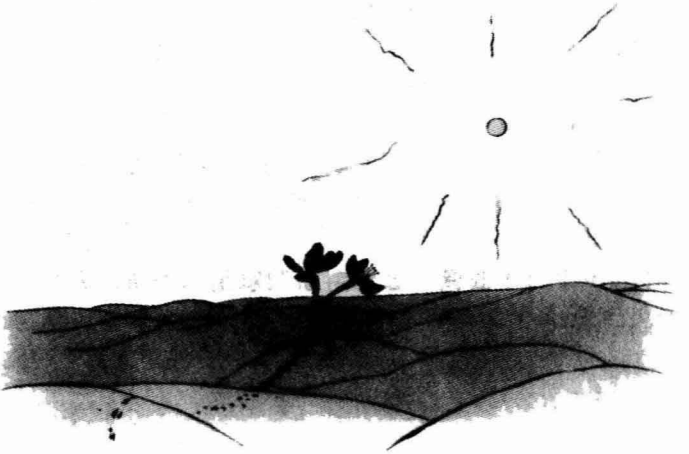
18

小王子穿过沙漠，只遇见一朵花。一朵三瓣的花，一朵极普通平凡的花……

“你好。”王子说。

“你好。”花儿说。

“人在哪儿呢?”小王子彬彬有礼地问。



花儿有一天曾看见一队骆驼走过。

“人?依我看,人是有的,大概六七个吧。好几年前我见过他们。但我不知道在哪儿能找到他们。风把他们吹散了。他们没有根,这就使他们吃尽了苦头。”

“别了。”小王子说。

“别了。”花儿说。

19

小王子登上一座高山。以前他只见过自己的那三座火山，火山很矮，才到他的膝盖。死火山只能给他当凳子坐。

“站在这座高山上，”他想道，“我一眼就能看见整个星球和所有的人了……”

但他只看见悬崖峭壁。

“您好。”他试探着喊道。

“您好……您好……您好……”回声应道。

“您是谁?”小王子问。

“您是谁……您是谁……您是谁……”回声应道。

“做我的朋友吧，我很孤单……”他说。

“我很孤单……我很孤单……我很孤单……”回声又答应道。

“多么古怪的星球!”小王子想道，“干干巴巴的，尖尖峭峭的，带点咸味儿的，这儿的人缺乏想象力，他们净重复别人讲过的话……而在我的那个星球里，我有一朵花，她总是抢先讲话……”

20

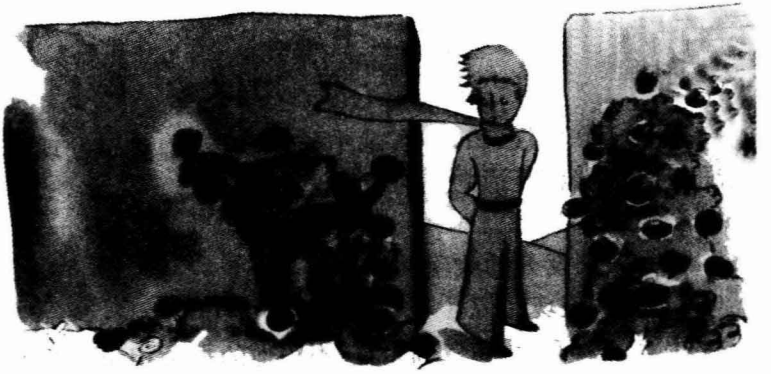
小王子在沙漠、山峰、大雪中长途跋涉。他终于看见了一条路，条条路都通向有人烟的地方。

“你们好。”他说。

这是一座盛开着玫瑰花的花园。

“你好。”玫瑰花们说。

小王子看着她们。她们一个个全像他的那朵花儿。



“你们是谁?”小王子大吃一惊,问她们说。

“我们是玫瑰花。”玫瑰花们说。

“啊!”小王子说……

小王子伤心极了。他的花儿告诉他,大千世界中,她是唯一的玫瑰花。可是在这儿,仅仅一座花园里就有五千朵玫瑰花,全都长得一模一样!

他想:“要是她看见这群玫瑰花,她又要恼羞成怒了……为了挽回面子,她又要装模作样地咳嗽,做出一副要死要活的样子,我也要呵护她,不然,她为了羞辱我,真会寻死的……”

他又想道:“我原以为我拥有一朵独一无二的花,我以为我很富足,原来她只是一朵极平常的花,她,以及我那三座只有我膝盖高的火山——其中一座也许永远都活不了,它们不能使我成为一位伟大的王子了……”

于是,他趴倒在草地上伤心地哭泣。

21

就在这个时候，出现了一只狐狸。

“你好。”狐狸说。

“你好。”小王子彬彬有礼地回答，他转过身，但看不见有什么东西。

“我在这里，”那声音说，“在苹果树下。”

“你是谁?”小王子说，“你真漂亮……”

“我是狐狸。”狐狸说。

“来跟我一起玩吧。”小王子向他建议，“我非常伤心……”

“我不能跟你一起玩，”狐狸说，“我不是驯养的动物。”

“哦，对不起。”小王子说。

小王子想了想，又问：

“什么叫做‘驯养’?”

“你不是本地人。”狐狸说，“人有枪，人打猎，太可恶了!可人也养鸡!这是人唯一的好处。你也找鸡吗?”

“不!”小王子说，“我找朋友。什么叫做‘驯养’?”

“这是一件被人遗忘干净的事了，” 狐狸说，“它的意思就是

‘建立联系’……”

“建立联系?”

“当然,”狐狸说,“对我而言,你不过是一个小男孩,和千千万万的小男孩没有两样。而且我不需要你,你也不需要我。对你而言,我只是一只狐狸,和千千万万只狐狸没有两样。但如果你驯养了我,我们就互相需要了。你就是我世界上唯一的人了,我也是你世上唯一的狐狸了……”

“我有点明白了。”小王子说,“有一朵花儿……我认为她驯养了我……”

“这可能,”狐狸说,“地球上有各色各样、形形色色的东西……”

“啊!她不在地球上。”小王子说。

狐狸露出大惊的神色。

“在另一个星球上?”

“是的。”

“那颗星球上,有猎人吗?”

“没有。”

“那可有意思了!有鸡吗?”

“没有。”

“世上就没有十全十美的东西。”狐狸叹了一口气。

狐狸又扯回原先的话题:

“我的生活枯燥乏味,异常单调。我逮鸡,人逮我。鸡全是一个模样,人也是一个模样,我都腻了。但如果你驯养我,我的生活就会充满阳光。我能辨得出与众不同的脚步声。别人的脚步声吓得我赶紧钻回

地洞。你的脚步声却像悦耳的音乐，召唤我走出洞穴。你瞧！你看那儿，那不是一片麦田吗？我不吃面包，我不需要小麦，麦田引不起我的想象力。说到这个，实在可悲！但你的头发是金灿灿的，它会叫我想起你的，我就会爱上风吹麦子的声音……”狐狸没说下去，对小王子瞧了好久，又说：

“请你……驯养我吧！”

“我很愿意，”小王子回答说，“但我的时间不多，我还要寻找朋友，还要了解许多新鲜的事物。”

“人只认识自己驯养的东西。”狐狸说，“人再没时间认识什么事

物。他们到商店买现成的东西，但没有一家商店是出售朋友的，人也就没有朋友了。如果你想要朋友，你就驯养我吧!”

“我该做些什么呢?”小王子说。

“需要非常的耐心。”狐狸回答说，“首先你要离我稍远点，坐着，像这样，坐在草地上。我斜瞟着你，你什么也别对我说。语言是误会的源泉。可是每天你可以坐得稍近一点……”

翌日，小王子又来了。

“最好在同一个时间来，”狐狸说，“例如，如果你是下午四点钟来的，从三点钟开始，我就开始感觉到幸福的滋味了。越接近四点钟，我越觉得幸福。到了四点钟，我就心神恍惚，坐立不安了。我发现了幸福的价值，但是如果你不按时来，我就不知道几点钟该装扮我的心，仪式还是需要的。”

“什么叫做‘仪式’?”小王子问。

“这也是一件被人遗忘干净了的事情。”狐狸说，“仪式就是使得某一日不同于其他日子，某一个小时不同于别的小时。比如说，猎人们有个仪式，每逢星期四，他们就与村里的姑娘们跳舞，星期四就成了再美妙不过的日子了!我也就可以到葡萄园里去闲逛了。如果猎人跳舞不挑日子，每一天都一样，我就没有假期了。”

于是小王子驯养狐狸了。小王子要走的时候到了。

“啊!”狐狸说，“……我想哭了。”

“这就是你的不对了，”小王子说，“我一点也不想伤害你，但你却要我驯养你……”

“不错。”狐狸说。

“但你却想哭!”小王子说。

“不错。”狐狸说。

“那你是一无所获了!”

“我有收获的,”狐狸说,“我得到了小麦的颜色。”

然后他又说:

“你去探望玫瑰花们吧,你就会明白,你的玫瑰花是世界上独一无二的花儿。然后你回来与我告别,我会送你一桩秘密作为礼物。”

小王子探望玫瑰花们,并对她们说:

“你们一点也不像我的玫瑰,你们还无足轻重,没有人驯养你们,你们也没有驯养任何人。你们的今天如同我的狐狸的昨天。昨天的他与千千万万的狐狸一样,但自从我让他做了我的朋友,他就是世上绝无仅有的狐狸了。”

玫瑰花们听了心里怪不自在的。

“你们长得很美,但你们的感情世界一片空白。”小王子还对她们说,“没有人为你们而死。不错,行人会认为我的玫瑰与你们没有两样,但只有她比你们重要,因为我给她浇了水,我给她盖上花罩,我给她竖起屏风,给她避风挡雨。我为她杀死了几条毛虫(有两三条我没杀,要让它们变成蝴蝶),我倾听她的抱怨,或她的吹嘘,有时也看着她默默无语的样子,因为她是我的玫瑰。”

他回到狐狸身边。

“别了。”他说……

“别了,”狐狸说,“这就是我的秘密,它很简单:用心去看才能看清楚,用眼睛是看不见本质的东西的。”

“用眼睛是看不见本质的东西的。”小王子重复念叨这句话，为了把它牢牢记住。

“你为你的玫瑰失去的时间，使你的玫瑰变得重要了。”

“我为我的玫瑰失去的时间，使我的玫瑰……”小王子说道，为了把它记住。

“人忘记了这条真理，”狐狸说，“但你不该忘。你应该永远对你驯养的对象负责，你要对你的玫瑰负责……”

“我要对我的玫瑰负责……”小王子反复念叨狐狸的教诲，为了牢牢记住它。

22

“你好。”小王子说。

“你好。”扳道工说。

“你在这儿干什么?”

“我给旅客们分组。一千人为一批。”扳道工说,“载乘客的火车也由我调度,它们有时开往左方,有时开往右方。”

一列灯火通明的火车风驰电掣般奔来,轰隆隆的响声震得调度室抖动摇晃。

“他们行色匆匆。”小王子说,“他们寻找什么?”

“坐在火车头上的人也不知道他们要寻找什么。”扳道工说。

第二列灯火通明的火车轰隆隆地从相反的方向奔驰而来。

“他们已经回来了?”小王子问……

“这列车坐的不是刚才那些人。”扳道工说,“这是对开的火车。”

“他们对他们的居住地不满意?”

“人总是这山望着那山高的。”扳道工说。

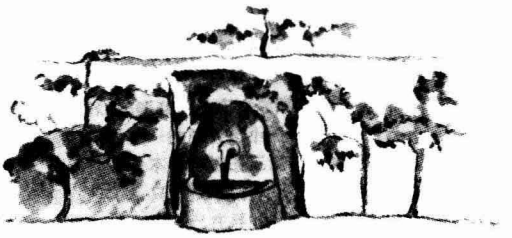
第三列灯火通明的火车也轰隆隆地响起来了。

“他们在追赶第一批旅客吗?”小王子问。

“他们从不追赶人，”扳道工说，“他们在车厢里睡大觉或打哈欠，只有孩子们才把鼻子贴在玻璃窗上看外面的世界。”

“只有孩子才知道他们要寻觅什么。”小王子说，“他们花不少时间与布娃娃玩，布娃娃变得很重要，如果有人抢走他们的布娃娃，他们就哭鼻子……”

“他们是有运气的人……”



23

“你好。”小王子说。

“你好。”商人说。

这位商人贩卖解渴的药丸。一个星期吃一颗这样的药丸，就不再需要喝水了。

“为什么你卖这种药?”小王子问。

“为了节省更多的时间，”商人说，“专家们计算过，每个星期能节省五十三分钟。”

“节省的这五十三分钟，有什么用途?”

“人可以干自己愿意干的事……”

小王子想：“要是我节省下这五十三分钟，我就要悠闲自在地朝一泓泉水走去……”

24

我的飞机在沙漠出故障的第八天，我听到了商人的故事，此时我储存的水已喝完了，一滴不剩。

我对小王子说：

“啊！你的这些回忆挺美好的，但我还没修好我的飞机，我的水也喝完了，如果我能悠闲自在地向一泓泉水走过去，我也会很幸福快活的！”

“我的朋友狐狸告诉我……”

“我的小人儿，别再说狐狸的事了！”

“为什么？”

“因为我快渴死了……”

他听不懂我说的理由。他说道：

“有个朋友真好，哪怕命在旦夕。我很满意狐狸做了我的朋友……”

我想：“他不知道危险的可怕，他从未尝过饥渴的滋味。他只要一点儿阳光就满足了……”

他看着我，似乎猜中了我的念头：

“我也渴……我们去找一口井吧……”

我做了个无法可想的手势。在一望无际的沙漠中寻一口井，这不是太荒唐了吗？但我们还是出发去寻找了。

我们默默地走了几个小时。夜幕降临，天上现出星星。由于干渴，我在发烧，看见星星，还以为自己在梦中呢。小王子说的话也似乎在我的脑海中跳跃。

“你也口渴了吗？”我问他。

他不回答我的问题，只简单地对我说：

“水对心也有好处……”

我听不懂他的话，但我不做声……我知道不应该问他。

他走乏了，坐了下来。我靠着他坐下。沉默了一会，他又说：

“星星美丽，因为里面有一朵看不见的花。”

我应了一句：“当然。”然后我不做声，看着月光下的起伏的沙丘。

“沙漠真美。”他又说。

他说得不错。我素来喜爱沙漠。我们坐在沙丘上。我们无所见，我们无所闻。然而，有什么东西在静静地发光……

“沙漠美丽，因为沙漠的某处隐藏着一口井。”小王子说。

我吃了一惊，因为我突然明白，沙漠中那神秘的闪闪发亮的东西是什么了。我还是一个小男孩的时候，住在一幢古老大屋里。传说里面埋藏着一件宝物。当然，没有一个人能找得到它。也许甚至没人去找它。但它像给这幢屋子施了魔法，让它凭空增添了吸引力。房里埋藏着秘密……

“你说得对，”我对小王子说，“房子也好，星星、沙漠也好，美化它

们的东西是肉眼看不见的!"

"我很欣慰,"他说,"你同意狐狸的看法。"

小王子入睡了。我把他抱在怀里,继续走我们的路。我受了感动。我觉得我抱着一件脆弱的宝物。我甚至觉得地球上没有比他更脆弱的东西了。借着银色的月光,我细细看他苍白的前额、闭着的双目、随风抖动的绺绺秀发。我心想:"我看见的只是一具躯壳,最重要的东西是看不见的……"

他半张的嘴唇上泛出浅浅的微笑。我又想:"这位睡着了的小王子打动了我,而打动了我的是他对花的忠贞。玫瑰花的倩影如同灯焰,在他心里闪闪发亮,即使是在梦乡……"

我把他想象得更脆弱了。灯是需要我们小心保护的,一股风就会把它吹灭……我就这样走着,曙光初露时我看见了那口井。

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“人挤在快车的车厢里，”小王子说，“却不知道他们要寻找什么。他们焦躁不安，团团乱转……”

他又说：

“这又何苦呢……”

我们找到的井不像撒哈拉沙漠的井。撒哈拉沙漠的井是在沙里挖个洞，而我们找到的这口井与村子里的井一样，可是这儿没有一个村子。我以为我正在做梦。

“这就奇了，”我对小王子说，“这井一切齐备：辘轳，水桶，绳子……”

他笑了，抓住绳子，转动辘轳。辘轳吱吱呀呀地叫唤，活像一只老风信鸡在风长睡时的叫唤。“你听，”小王子说，“我们唤醒了这口井。它在唱歌呢……”

我不忍心看他劳力费神。

“让我来干吧，”我对他说，“你干这活太重了。”

我轻轻把水桶提到井口，垂直放进井内。倾听着辘轳的歌声，还看见在荡漾的井水中摇动的太阳。

“我渴望的就是这样的水，”小王子说，“让我喝上几口……”我明白他要寻找什么了。

我把桶举到他的唇边。他闭着双目喝水。水甜得有如过节。这水不仅是饮料，它还是别的东西。它是经过星光下的跋涉，在辘轳的歌声中和我双臂的努力下诞生的。它像礼物一样愉悦心灵。我还是小男孩的时候，圣诞树上挂的灯、子夜弥撒的音乐、甜蜜的微笑，是我收到的圣诞礼物的光芒。

“你们这儿的人在一个园里种植五千株玫瑰……但他们却找不到他们寻觅的东西……”

“他们没找到。”我说……

“然而他们寻找的东西是可以在一朵玫瑰或一点点水里找到的……”

“不错。”我回答说。

小王子又说：

“然而肉眼是看不见的，要用心灵去寻找。”

我喝了水，呼吸畅通了。天亮时分，沙子颜色如蜜。我也喜欢蜜般的颜色。但为什么我的心里总有点不快乐呢？……

“你可要履行诺言啊。”小王子轻声对我说，他又靠近我坐着。

“什么诺言？”

“你知道的呀……给我的绵羊画一个口罩，我要对我的花儿负责呀！”

我从口袋里掏出画稿。小王子看后，笑着对我说：

“你画的猴面包树有点像卷心菜……”

“呀!”

我还为我画的猴面包树自鸣得意呢!

“你画的狐狸……它的耳朵……有点像角……太长了!”

他还在笑。

“你不公平,小人儿。我并不会画画,只会画打开了肚子的蟒蛇和没打开肚子的蟒蛇。”

“啊!很不错的嘛,孩子们看得懂的。”他说。

我用铅笔画了一个口罩,把它交给他的时候,我的心揪得紧紧的:

“你已有了我不知道的计划吧……”

但他避而不答。他只对我说:

“你知道,我落到地球上……明天已是一周年了……”

然后,沉默片刻,他又说:

“当时我就落在附近……”

他的脸红了。

不知何故,我有说不出来的惆怅悲哀。我提出了一个问题:

“这么说,一个星期之前,认识你的那天早上,你不是偶尔一人来到这远离人烟的沙漠的?你要回到你的降落点去?”

小王子的脸又红了。

我犹豫着又问:

“也许是为了纪念降落周年?……”

小王子的脸再次红了。他从不回答我提的问题。但一个人脸红,就意味着默认,意味着做了“是的”的回答,对吧?

“啊!”我对他说,“我怕……”

他却对我说:

“现在你该干活了。你该到你的机器旁忙活儿了。我在这儿等你,明天晚上再来……”

但我不放心。我想起了狐狸的事,让别人驯养,难免要掉掉眼泪……

26

井旁有一堵断墙残壁。第二天晚上，我干完活回来，远远看见我的小王子坐在残壁上，双腿悬空。我听见他说：

“你不记得了吗?不完全在这里!”

无疑有另一个声音回了他的话，因为他反驳说：

“没错!没错!就是这一天，但不是这个地方……”

我向断墙残壁走过去，我看不见也听不见有什么人在那儿。然而小王子又反驳了：

“……当然，你会看到我留在沙地上的足迹，看到它是从哪儿开始的。你在那儿等我就行了。今夜我会在那儿等你。”

我离墙才二十米，还是一无所见。

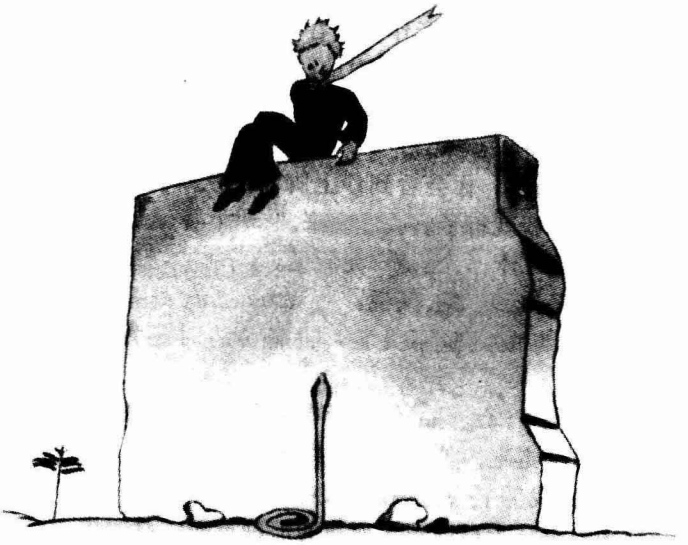
小王子沉默片刻后又说：

“你有毒液吗?你能肯定不让我经受很久的痛苦?”

我停住了脚步，心被揪成一团。我仍然听不懂他的话。

“现在你走吧。”他说，“我要跳下去了!”

我的眼光落到墙根，我吓了一跳!一条黄蛇正仰头朝向小王子。这种黄蛇最毒了，三十秒钟内就能要你的命。我一面伸手到口袋里掏



手枪，一面飞步冲过去。蛇听到我的脚步声，轻轻地溜进沙里，如颓然跌落的水柱，不慌不忙地钻进石缝里，发出轻微的金属的声音。

我及时赶到墙边，用双臂接住我的小人儿。这位王子的脸雪一般的苍白。

“怎么回事，你和蛇说话了？”

我解下他从不离身的金围巾，用水湿湿他的太阳穴，给他喝水。现在我不敢再向他提什么问题了。他神情凝重地看着我，双臂搂住我的脖子。我感觉到他的心的狂跳，如同中弹濒死的小鸟。

他对我说：“你找到了机器的毛病，我很高兴。你可以回家了……”

“你怎么知道的?”

我来找他,正是要告诉他:出乎我的意料,我竟修好了我的飞机。

他不回答我的问题,却又说:

“今天我也要回家了……”

然后,他神色凄伤,黯然说道:

“我的家要远多了……也难回去得多……”

我感觉到发生了非比寻常的事情。我把他搂进怀里,如同他是个小孩子。然而我觉得他直往深渊里坠下去,我一点也抓不住他……

他目光严肃,落到远方。

“我有你的绵羊,我有给绵羊住的箱子。我有口罩……”

他凄凉地笑笑。

我等了许久。我感觉到他的身体逐渐恢复了温暖。

“小人儿,你害怕了……”

当然,他害怕!他温和地笑笑:

“今晚我会更害怕!”

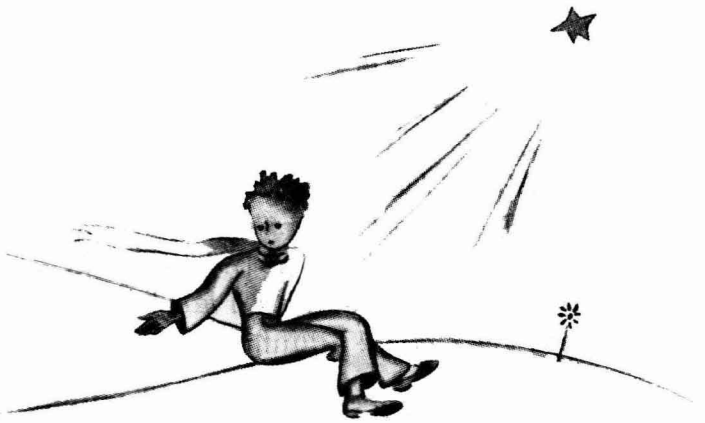
我又一次体会到无可奈何的感觉。我全身冰冷。我知道,听不见他的笑声,我会忍受不了的。他的笑声对我来说,如同沙漠里的一口井。

“小人儿,我还想听到你的笑声……”

但他对我说:

“今夜是我到这儿的一周年。我的星星正好在我去年降落处的正上方……”

“小人儿,蛇呀,约会呀,星星的故事,莫非都是一场噩梦?……”



但他不回答我的问题。他对我说：

“最重要的东西，是肉眼看不到的……”

“当然……”

“花儿也是这样，如果你爱上了一朵长在一颗星星里的花儿，夜里看看星空，你会觉得甜蜜。所有的星星都像开了花。”

“不错……”

“水也是这样。你给我喝的水，有了辘轳和绳子，水就如同音乐……你记得……它是甘甜的。”

“不错。”

“夜里你仰望星空吧，我的那颗星太渺小，没法子告诉你它在哪儿。这样更好……你就把我的星看做是万千星星中的一颗吧，这样你就会爱看所有的星星……它们全都成了你的朋友。然后我会赠给你一份礼物……”

他还在笑。

“啊，小人儿，小人儿，我喜欢听你的笑声！”

“这正是我给你的礼物……这就和水一样……”

“你想说什么？”

“不同的人有不同的星星。星星是旅行的人的向导，星星只是其他人的小灯，星星是学者研究的问题，星星是我说过的那个商人的金子。但所有的星星都沉默不语。你的那颗星星是别人没有的……”

“你想说什么？”

“既然我住在天上一颗星星里，既然我在其中一颗星星里笑，这就如同所有的星星都在冲你笑，你就拥有无数会笑的星星了！”

他还在笑。

“你得到了安慰之后(人常常自我安慰)，你会为认识我而高兴。你会成为我永远的朋友，你会想与我一起笑。有时候，当你想笑而打开窗户的时候……你的朋友看见你仰望星空独自发笑，他们一定会惊讶，你就对他们说：‘是的，我看见星星就要笑！’他们会以为你神经出了毛病。看来是我捉弄了你了……”

他还在笑。

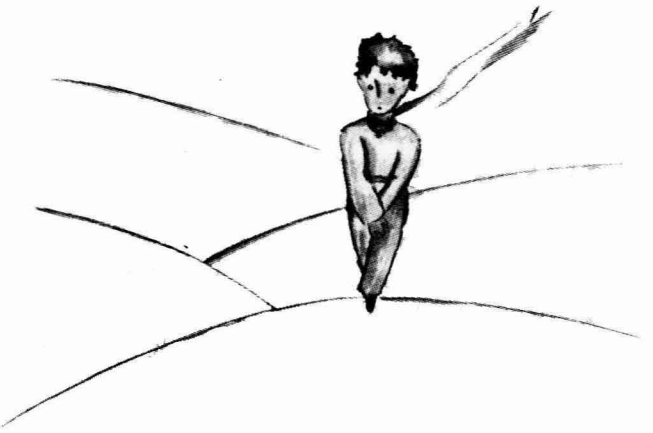
“这样一来，我给你的不是星星，而是一大批会笑的小铃铛……”

他还在笑。然后他收敛了笑容：

“今晚……你知道……你不要来了。”

“我不会离开你的。”

“我会很难看的……会像个死人，别来看我的死了的样子，没有必要。”



“我不会离开你的。”

他露出忧心忡忡的神色。

“我跟你讲这些话……也是因为蛇，不该让它伤害你……蛇是凶残的动物，高兴时也咬人……”

“我不离开你。”

他想起什么，随即放宽了心：

“真的，蛇咬的第二口不再有毒液……”

那天夜里我没看见他离开我。他是悄悄走的。我终于赶上他。他大步走着，步子迈得又大又坚决。他见了我，只说了一句：“呀，你在这儿……”

他牵住我的手。然后他苦恼地说：

“你不该来的。你会难过的。我会像个死人，其实我不是真死……”

我不做声。

“你知道吧，路途太远，我拖不动这副皮囊，它太沉了。”

我不做声。

“也不过如同蜕了旧壳，一副旧壳不值得悲哀……”

我还是不做声。

他有点泄气了，但还在竭力安慰我：

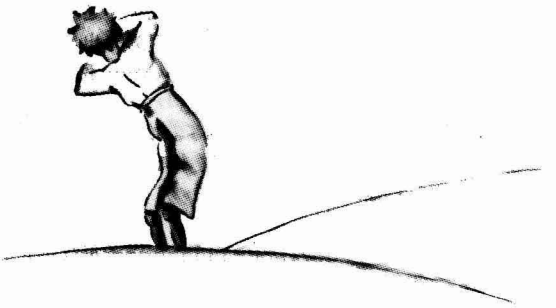
“你知道，想起你，我的心会温暖的。以后我也会仰望星空，所有的星星会成了带有生锈辘轳的井，所有的星星给我倒水喝……”

我还是不做声。

“那会是多么有意思的事情哟！你会有五亿个小铃铛，我有五亿口井……”

他也不做声了，因为他哭了……

“就在这儿吧。你让我独自走一步。”



他坐了下来，因为他害怕了。

他还说：

“你知道……我的花……我要对她负责！她弱不禁风！她聪明纯洁！她一无所有！只凭四根刺保护自己，抵御世上的侵害……”

我瘫坐在地上。因为我站不住了。他说：

“我的话……讲完了……”

他还犹豫了片刻，然后站起来，向前走了一步。而我不能动弹。

他的脚踝边闪了一道黄光。他凝然不动。他没有叫喊。好一会儿之后，他像大树倒地似的倒下。因为这儿是沙地，他倒下去的时候，一点声音都没有。

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当然，这已是六年前的事了……我从来没对别人讲过这个故事。我的同事们看见我活着回来，都替我庆幸。我神色哀伤，但我告诉他们："这是因为累……"

现在，我的离愁别绪已经减轻了一些。也就是说……还没有完全消除。我很明白，他回他的星球去了，因为天亮时我没找到他的尸体。他的躯体并不沉重……我喜欢在夜里倾听星星的呢喃，它们就像五亿个小铃铛……

可是出了非同寻常的事了：我给小王子画了口罩，但我忘了给口罩配上皮带！他别想把口罩套上羊嘴了。我于是想："他的星球发生了什么事呢？绵羊很可能吃了花儿……"

有时我又想："一定不会的！小王子每天夜里把他的花儿罩在玻璃罩里，他一定会看管好他的绵羊……"于是我放心了，天上所有的星星都温和地微笑。

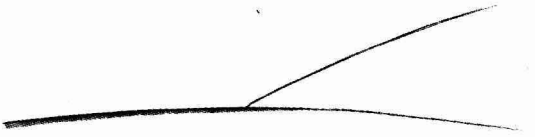
有时我想："人总免不了有疏忽大意的时候，这就够糟的了！要是有天晚上他忘了给花罩上玻璃罩，或者绵羊在夜里悄悄地溜出来呢……"于是，铃铛全变成了泪珠……

这件事始终是无法解开的谜。在宇宙中不知哪个角落，我们不认识的绵羊有没有吃掉一朵玫瑰花，你们——喜爱小王子的人，和我一样，看法绝不相同……

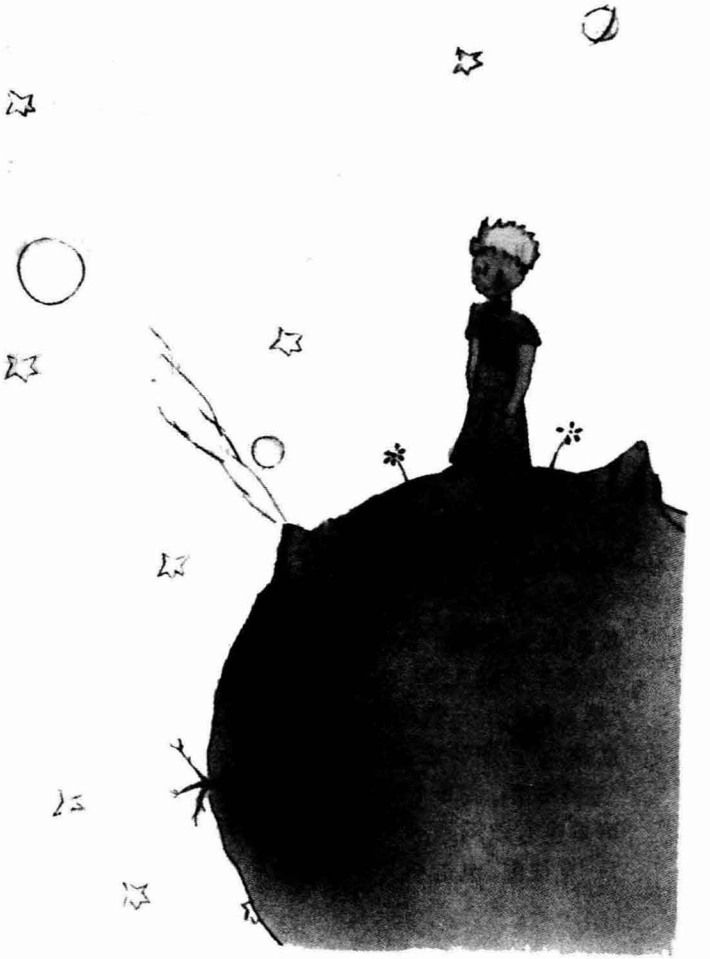
请你们仰望星空吧。请你们问问自己：绵羊有没有吃掉花儿？你们就会看到，天上所有的星星发生了变化……

没有一个大人明白，弄清楚这个问题有多重要！

我认为这幅图画是世界上最凄美的图画了。它与前一页的画面一样。我再一次画它，是为了让你们好好地看看它。小王子就是在这里出现在地球上的，然后又是从这里离开了地球。请你们仔细看清楚这幅画，有朝一日你们到沙漠，到非洲旅行，才能认出这地方来。如果你经过这个地方，我恳求你们，别匆忙离去，请在那颗星下稍待片刻！如果有个孩子向你走过来，如果他笑吟吟的，如果他长着一头金发，如果你向他提问题，他不回答，你们就会猜到他是谁了。果真如此，请你们行行好！别眼睁睁看着我为思念他而悲伤，别坐视不理，别无动于衷：请你们快点写信告诉我，他回来了……



The Little Prince



To Léon Werth

I ask the indulgence of the children who may read this book for dedicating it to a grown-up. I have a serious reason: he is the best friend I have in the world. I have another reason: this grown-up understands everything, even books about children. I have a third reason: he lives in France where he is hungry and cold. He needs cheering up. If all these reasons are not enough, I will dedicate the book to the child from whom this grown-up grew. All grown-ups were once children—although few of them remember it. And so I correct my dedication:

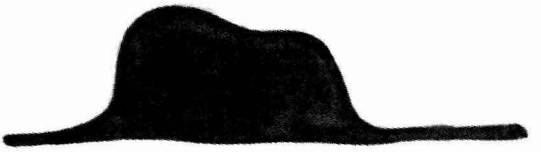
To Léon Werth
when he was a little boy

I

Once when I was six years old I saw a magnificent picture in a book, called *True Stories from Nature,* about the primeval forest. It was a picture of a boa constrictor in the act of swallowing an animal. Here is a copy of the drawing.

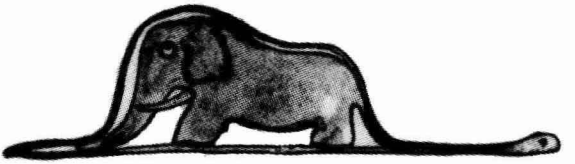
In the book it said: "Boa constrictors swallow their prey whole, without chewing it. After that they are not able to move, and they sleep through the six months that they need for digestion."

I pondered deeply, then, over the adventures of the jungle. And after some work with a colored pencil I succeeded in making my first drawing. My Drawing Number One. It looked something like this:



I showed my masterpiece to the grown-ups, and asked them whether the drawing frightened them. But they answered: "Frighten? Why should any one be frightened by a hat?"

My drawing was not a picture of a hat. It was a picture of a boa constrictor digesting an elephant. But since the grown-ups were not able to understand it, I made another drawing: I drew the inside of a boa constrictor, so that the grown-ups could see it clearly. They always need to have things explained. My Drawing Number Two looked like this:



The grown-ups' response, this time, was to advise me to lay aside my drawings of boa constrictors, whether from the inside or the outside, and devote myself instead to geography, history, arithmetic, and grammar. That is why, at the age of six, I gave up what might have been a magnificent career as a painter. I had been disheartened by the failure of my Drawing Number One and my Drawing Number Two. Grown-ups never understand anything by themselves, and it is tiresome for children to be always and forever explaining things to them.

So then I chose another profession, and learned to pilot airplanes. I have flown a little over all parts of the world; and it is true that geography has been very useful to me. At a glance I can distinguish China from Arizona. If one gets lost in the night, such knowledge is valuable.

In the course of this life I have had a great many encounters with a great many people who have been concerned with matters of consequence. I have lived a great deal among grown-ups. I have seen them intimately, close at hand. And that hasn't much improved my opinion of them.

Whenever I met one of them who seemed to me at all clear-sighted, I tried the experiment of showing him my Drawing Number One, which I have always kept. I would try to find out, so, if this was a person of true understanding. But, whoever it was, he, or she, would always say:

"That is a hat."

Then I would never talk to that person about boa constrictors, or primeval forests, or stars. I would bring myself down to his level. I would talk to him about bridge, and golf, and politics, and neckties. And the grown-up would be greatly pleased to have met such a sensible man.

II

So I lived my life alone, without anyone that I could really talk to, until I had an accident with my plane in the Desert of Sahara, six years ago. Something was broken in my engine. And as I had with me neither a mechanic nor any passengers, I set myself to attempt the difficult repairs all alone. It was a question of life or death for me: I had scarcely enough drinking water to last a week.

The first night, then, I went to sleep on the sand, a thousand miles from any human habitation. I was more isolated than a shipwrecked sailor on a raft in the middle of the ocean. Thus you can imagine my amazement, at sunrise, when I was awakened by an odd little voice. It said:

"If you please—draw me a sheep!"

"What!"

"Draw me a sheep!"

I jumped to my feet, completely thunderstruck. I blinked my eyes hard. I looked carefully all around me. And I saw a most extraordinary small person, who stood there examining me with great seriousness. Here you may see the best portrait that, later, I was able to make of him. But my drawing is certainly very much less charming than its model.

That, however, is not my fault. The grown-ups discouraged me in my painter's career when I was six years old, and I never learned to draw anything, except boas from the outside and boas from the inside.

Now I stared at this sudden apparition with my eyes fairly starting out of my head in astonishment. Remember, I had crashed in the desert a thousand miles from any inhabited region. And yet my little man seemed neither to be straying uncertainly among the sands, nor to be fainting from fatigue or hunger or thirst or fear. Nothing about him gave any suggestion of a child lost in the middle of the desert, a thousand miles from any human habitation. When at last I was able to speak, I said to him:

"But—what are you doing here?"

And in answer he repeated, very slowly, as if he were speaking of a matter of great consequence:

"If you please—draw me a sheep..."

When a mystery is too overpowering, one dare not disobey. Absurd as it might seem to me, a thousand miles from any human habitation and in danger of death, I took out of my pocket a sheet of paper and my fountain-pen. But then I remembered how my studies had been concentrated on geography, history, arithmetic and grammar, and I told the little chap (a little crossly, too) that I did not know how to draw. He answered me:

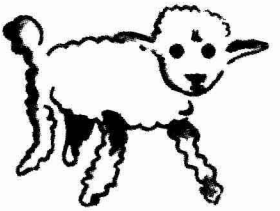
"That doesn't matter. Draw me a sheep..."

But I had never drawn a sheep. So I drew for him one of the two pictures I had drawn so often. It was that of the boa constrictor from the outside. And I was astounded to hear the little fellow greet it with:

"No, no, no! I do not want an elephant inside a boa

constrictor. A boa constrictor is a very dangerous creature, and an elephant is very cumbersome. Where I live, everything is very small. What I need is a sheep. Draw me a sheep."

So then I made a drawing.



He looked at it carefully, then he said:

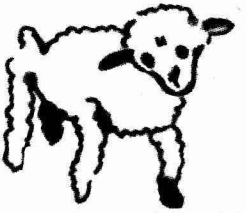
"No. This sheep is already very sickly. Make me another."

So I made another drawing.

My friend smiled gently and indulgently.

"You see yourself," he said, "that this is not a sheep. This is a ram. It has horns."

So then I did my drawing over once more.



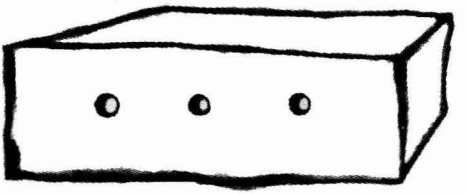
But it was rejected too, just like the others.

"This one is too old. I want a sheep that will live a long time."

By this time my patience was exhausted, because I was in a hurry to start taking my engine apart. So I tossed off this drawing.

And I threw out an explanation with it.

"This is only his box. The sheep you asked for is inside."



I was very surprised to see a light break over the face of my young judge:

"That is exactly the way I wanted it! Do you think that this sheep will have to have a great deal of grass?"

"Why?"

"Because where I live everything is very small..."

"There will surely be enough grass for him," I said. "It is a very small sheep that I have given you."

He bent his head over the drawing.

"Not so small that—Look! He has gone to sleep..."

And that is how I made the acquaintance of the little prince.

III

It took me a long time to learn where he came from. The little prince, who asked me so many questions, never seemed to hear the ones I asked him. It was from words dropped by chance that, little by little, everything was revealed to me.

The first time he saw my airplane, for instance (I shall not draw my airplane; that would be much too complicated for me), he asked me:

"What is that object?"

"That is not an object. It flies. It is an airplane. It is my airplane."

And I was proud to have him learn that I could fly. He cried out, then:

"What! You dropped down from the sky?"

"Yes," I answered, modestly.

"Oh! That is funny!"

And the little prince broke into a lovely peal of laughter, which irritated me very much. I like my misfortunes to be taken seriously. Then he added:

"So you, too, come from the sky! Which is your planet?"

At that moment I caught a gleam of light in the impenetrable mystery of his presence; and I demanded, abruptly:

"Do you come from another planet?"

But he did not reply. He tossed his head gently, without taking his eyes from my plane:

"It is true that on that you can't have come from very far away..."

And he sank into a reverie, which lasted a long time. Then, taking my sheep out of his pocket, he buried himself in the contemplation of his treasure.

You can imagine how my curiosity was aroused by this half-confidence about the "other planets." I made a great effort, therefore, to find out more on this subject.

"My little man, where do you come from? What is this 'where I live,' of which you speak? Where do you want to take your sheep?" After a reflective silence he answered:

"The thing that is so good about the box you have given me is that at night he can use it as his house."

"That is so. And if you are good I will give you a string, too, so that you can tie him during the day, and a post to tie him to." But the little prince seemed shocked by this offer:

"Tie him! What a queer idea!"

"But if you don't tie him," I said, "he will wander off somewhere, and get lost."

My friend broke into another peal of laughter:

"But where do you think he would go?"

"Anywhere. Straight ahead of him."

Then the little prince said, earnestly:

"That doesn't matter. Where I live, everything is so small!"

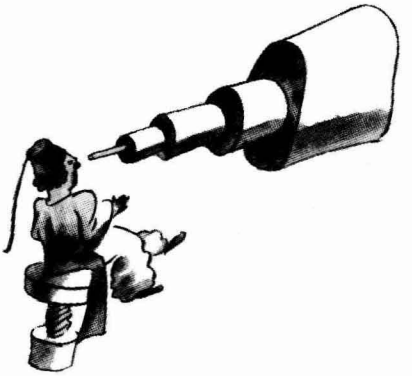
And, with perhaps a hint of sadness, he added:

"Straight ahead of him, nobody can go very far..."

IV

I had thus learned a second fact of great importance: this was that the planet the little prince came from was scarcely any larger than a house!

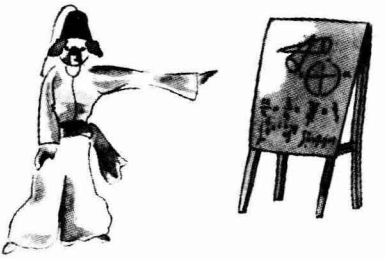
But that did not really surprise me much. I knew very well that in addition to the great planets—such as the Earth, Jupiter,



Mars, Venus—to which we have given names, there are also hundreds of others, some of which are so small that one has a hard time seeing them through the telescope. When an astronomer discovers one of these he does not give it a name, but only a number. He might call it, for example, "Asteroid 325".

I have serious reason to believe that the planet from which the little prince came is the asteroid known as B-612.

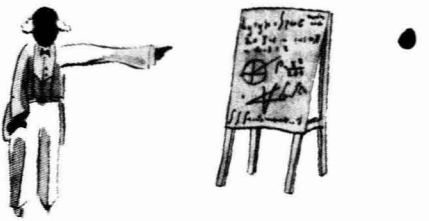
This asteroid has only once been seen through the telescope. That was by a Turkish astronomer, in 1909.



On making his discovery, the astronomer had presented it to the International Astronomical Congress, in a great demonstration. But he was in Turkish costume, and so nobody would believe what he said.

Grown-ups are like that...

Fortunately, however, for the reputation of Asteroid B-612, a Turkish dictator made a law that his subjects, under pain of death, should change to European costume. So in 1920 the astronomer gave his demonstration all over again, dressed with impressive style and elegance. And this time everybody accepted his report.



If I have told you these details about the asteroid, and made a note of its number for you, it is on account of the grown-ups and their ways. When you tell them that you have made a new friend, they never ask you any questions about essential matters. They never say to you, "What does his voice sound like? What games does he love best? Does he collect butterflies?" Instead, they demand: "How old is he? How many brothers has he? How much does he weigh? How much money does his father make?" Only from these figures do they think they have learned anything about him.

If you were to say to the grown-ups: "I saw a beautiful house made of rosy brick, with geraniums in the windows and doves on the roof," they would not be able to get any idea of that house at all. You would have to say to them: "I saw a house that cost $20,000." Then they would exclaim: "Oh, what a pretty house that is!"

Just so, you might say to them: "The proof that the little prince existed is that he was charming, that he laughed, and that he was looking for a sheep. If anybody wants a sheep, that is a

proof that he exists." And what good would it do to tell them that? They would shrug their shoulders, and treat you like a child. But if you said to them: "The planet he came from is Asteroid B-612," then they would be convinced, and leave you in peace from their questions.

They are like that. One must not hold it against them. Children should always show great forbearance toward grown-up people. But certainly, for us who understand life, figures are a matter of indifference. I should have liked to begin this story in the fashion of the fairy-tales. I should have like to say: "Once upon a time there was a little prince who lived on a planet that was scarcely any bigger than himself, and who had need of a sheep..."

To those who understand life, that would have given a much greater air of truth to my story.

For I do not want any one to read my book carelessly. I have suffered too much grief in setting down these memories. Six years have already passed since my friend went away from me, with his sheep. If I try to describe him here, it is to make sure that I shall not forget him. To forget a friend is sad. Not every one has had a friend. And if I forget him, I may become like the grown-ups who are no longer interested in anything but figures...

It is for that purpose, again, that I have bought a box of paints and some pencils. It is hard to take up drawing again at my age, when I have never made any pictures except those of the boa constrictor from the outside and the boa constrictor from the inside,

since I was six. I shall certainly try to make my portraits as true to life as possible. But I am not at all sure of success. One drawing goes along all right, and another has no resemblance to its subject. I make some errors, too, in the little prince's height: in one place he is too tall and in another too short. And I feel some doubts about the color of his costume. So I fumble along as best I can, now good, now bad, and I hope generally fair-to-middling.

In certain more important details I shall make mistakes, also. But that is something that will not be my fault. My friend never explained anything to me. He thought, perhaps, that I was like himself. But I, alas, do not know how to see sheep through the walls of boxes. Perhaps I am a little like the grown-ups. I have had to grow old.

V

As each day passed I would learn, in our talk, something about the little prince's planet, his departure from it, his journey. The information would come very slowly, as it might chance to fall from his thoughts. It was in this way that I heard, on the third day, about the catastrophe of the baobabs.

This time, once more, I had the sheep to thank for it. For the little prince asked me abruptly—as if seized by a grave doubt—"It is true, isn't it, that sheep eat little bushes?"

"Yes, that is true."

"Ah! I am glad!"

I did not understand why it was so important that sheep should eat little bushes. But the little prince added:

"Then it follows that they also eat baobabs?"

I pointed out to the little prince that baobabs were not little

bushes, but, on the contrary, trees as big as castles; and that even if he took a whole herd of elephants away with him, the herd would not eat up one single baobab. The idea of the herd of elephants made the little prince laugh.

"We would have to put them one on top of the other," he said.

But he made a wise comment:

"Before they grow so big, the baobabs start out by being little."

"That is strictly correct," I said. "But why do you want the sheep to eat the little baobabs?"

He answered me at once, "Oh, come, come!", as if he were speaking of something that was self-evident. And I was obliged to make a great mental effort to solve this problem, without any assistance.

Indeed, as I learned, there were on the planet where the little

prince lived—as on all planets—good plants and bad plants. In consequence, there were good seeds from good plants, and bad seeds from bad plants. But seeds are invisible. They sleep deep in the heart of the earth's darkness, until some one among them is seized with the desire to awaken. Then this little seed will stretch itself and begin—timidly at first—to push a charming little sprig inoffensively upward toward the sun. If it is only a sprout of radish or the sprig of a rose-bush, one would let it grow wherever it might wish. But when it is a bad plant, one must destroy it as soon as possible, the very first instant that one recognizes it.

Now there were some terrible seeds on the planet that was the home of the little prince; and these were the seeds of the baobab. The soil of that planet was infested with them. A baobab is something you will never, never be able to get rid of if you attend to it too late. It spreads over the entire planet. It bores clear through it with its roots. And if the planet is too small, and the baobabs are too many, they split it in pieces...

"It is a question of discipline," the little prince said to me later on. "When you've finished your own toilet in the morning, then it is time to attend to the toilet of your planet, just so, with the greatest care. You must see to it that you pull up regularly all the baobabs, at the very first moment when they can be distinguished from the rosebushes which they resemble so closely in their earliest youth. It is very tedious work," the little prince added, "but very easy."

And one day he said to me: "You ought to make a beautiful drawing, so that the children where you live can see exactly how all this is. That would be very useful to them if they were to travel some day. Sometimes," he added, "there is no harm in putting off a piece of work until another day. But when it is a matter of baobabs, that always means a catastrophe. I knew a planet that was inhabited by a lazy man. He neglected three little bushes..."

So, as the little prince described it to me, I have made a drawing of that planet. I do not much like to take the tone of a moralist. But the danger of the baobabs is so little understood, and such considerable risks would be run by anyone who might get lost on an asteroid, that for once I am breaking through my reserve. "Children," I say plainly, "watch out for the baobabs!" My friends, like myself, have been skirting this danger for a long time, without ever knowing it; and so it is for them that I have worked so hard over this drawing. The lesson which I pass on by this means is worth all the trouble it has cost me.

Perhaps you will ask me, "Why are there no other drawing in this book as magnificent and impressive as this drawing of the baobabs?" The reply is simple. I have tried. But with the others I have not been successful. When I made the drawing of the baobabs I was carried beyond myself by the inspiring force of urgent necessity.

VI

Oh, little prince! Bit by bit I came to understand the secrets of your sad little life... For a long time you had found your only entertainment in the quiet pleasure of looking at the sunset. I learned that new detail on the morning of the fourth day, when you said to me:

"I am very fond of sunsets. Come, let us go look at a sunset now."

"But we must wait," I said.

"Wait? For what?"

"For the sunset. We must wait until it is time."

At first you seemed to be very much surprised. And then you laughed to yourself. You said to me:

"I am always thinking that I am at home!"

Just so. Everybody knows that when it is noon in the United

States the sun is setting over France. If you could fly to France in one minute, you could go straight into the sunset, right from noon. Unfortunately, France is too far away for that. But on your tiny planet, my little prince, all you need do is move your chair a few steps. You can see the day end and the twilight falling whenever you like...

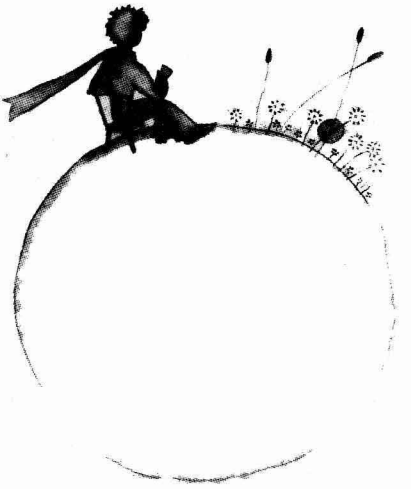
"One day," you said to me, "I saw the sunset forty-four times!"

And a little later you added:

"You know—one loves the sunset, when one is so sad..."

"Were you so sad, then?" I asked, "on the day of the forty-four sunsets?"

But the little prince made no reply.



VII

On the fifth day—again, as always, it was thanks to the sheep—the secret of the little prince's life was revealed to me. Abruptly, without anything to lead up to it, and as if the question had been born of long and silent meditation on his problem, he demanded:

"A sheep—if it eats little bushes, does it eat flowers, too?"

"A sheep," I answered, "eats anything it finds in its reach."

"Even flowers that have thorns?"

"Yes, even flowers that have thorns."

"Then the thorns—what use are they?"

I did not know. At that moment I was very busy trying to unscrew a bolt that had got stuck in my engine. I was very much worried, for it was becoming clear to me that the breakdown of my plane was extremely serious. And I had so little

drinking-water left that I had to fear for the worst.

"The thorns—what use are they?"

The little prince never let go of a question, once he had asked it. As for me, I was upset over that bolt. And I answered with the first thing that came into my head:

"The thorns are of no use at all. Flowers have thorns just for spite!"

"Oh!"

There was a moment of complete silence. Then the little prince flashed back at me, with a kind of resentfulness:

"I don't believe you! Flowers are weak creatures. They are naive. They reassure themselves as best they can. They believe that their thorns are terrible weapons..."

I did not answer. At that instant I was saying to myself: "If this bolt still won't turn, I am going to knock it out with the hammer." Again the little prince disturbed my thoughts:

"And you actually believe that the flowers—"

"Oh, no!" I cried. "No, no, no! I don't believe anything. I answered you with the first thing that came into my head. Don't you see—I am very busy with matters of consequence!"

He stared at me, thunderstruck.

"Matters of consequence!"

He looked at me there, with my hammer in my hand, my fingers black with engine-grease, bending down over an object which seemed to him extremely ugly...

"You talk just like the grown-ups!"

That made me a little ashamed. But he went on, relentlessly:

"You mix everything up together... You confuse everything..."

He was really very angry. He tossed his golden curls in the breeze.

"I know a planet where there is a certain red-faced gentleman. He has never smelled a flower. He has never looked at a star. He has never loved any one. He has never done anything in his life but add up figures. And all day he says over and over, just like you: 'I am busy with matters of consequence!' And that makes him swell up with pride. But he is not a man—he is a mushroom!"

"A what?"

"A mushroom!"

The little prince was now white with rage.

"The flowers have been growing thorns for millions of years. For millions of years the sheep have been eating them just the same. And is it not a matter of consequence to try to understand why the flowers go to so much trouble to grow thorns which are never of any use to them? Is the warfare between the sheep and the flowers not important? Is this not of more consequence than a fat red-faced gentleman's sums? And if I know—I, myself—one flower which is unique in the world, which grows nowhere but on my planet, but which one little sheep can destroy in a single bite some morning, without even noticing what he is doing—Oh!

You think that is not important!"

His face turned from white to red as he continued:

"If some one loves a flower, of which just one single blossom grows in all the millions and millions of stars, it is enough to make him happy just to look at the stars. He can say to himself, 'Somewhere, my flower is there...' But if the sheep eats the flower, in one moment all his stars will be darkened... And you think that is not important!"

He could not say anything more. His words were choked by sobbing.

The night had fallen. I had let my tools drop from my hands. Of what moment now was my hammer, my bolt, or thirst, or death? On one star, one planet, my planet, the Earth, there was a little prince to be comforted. I took him in my arms, and rocked him. I said to him:

"The flower that you love is not in danger. I will draw you a muzzle for your sheep. I will draw you a railing to put around your flower. I will—"

I did not know what to say to him. I felt awkward and blundering. I did not know how I could reach him, where I could overtake him and go on hand in hand with him once more.

It is such a secret place, the land of tears.

VIII

I soon learned to know this flower better. On the little prince's planet the flowers had always been very simple. They had only one ring of petals; they took up no room at all; they were a trouble to nobody. One morning they would appear in the grass, and by night they would have faded peacefully away. But one day, from a seed blown from no one knew where, a new flower had come up; and the little prince had watched very closely over this small sprout which was not like any other small sprouts on his planet. It might, you see, have been a new kind of baobab.

The shrub soon stopped growing, and began to get ready to produce a flower. The little prince, who was present at the first appearance of a huge bud, felt at once that some sort of miraculous apparition must emerge from it. But the flower was not satisfied to complete the preparations for her beauty in the shelter of

her green chamber. She chose her colors with the greatest care. She dressed herself slowly. She adjusted her petals one by one. She did not wish to go out into the world all rumpled, like the field poppies. It was only in the full radiance of her beauty that she wished to appear. Oh, yes! She was a coquettish creature! And her mysterious adornment lasted for days and days.

Then one morning, exactly at sunrise, she suddenly showed herself.

And, after working with all this painstaking precision, she yawned and said:

"Ah! I am scarcely awake. I beg that you will excuse me. My petals are still all disarranged..."

But the little prince could not restrain his admiration:

"Oh! How beautiful you are!"

"Am I not?" the flower responded, sweetly. "And I was born at the same moment as the sun..."

The little prince could guess easily enough that she was not any too modest—but how moving—and exciting—she was!

"I think it is time for breakfast," she added an instant later. "If you would have the kindness to think of my needs—"

And the little prince, completely abashed, went to look for a sprinkling-can of fresh water. So, he tended the flower. So, too, she began very quickly to torment him with her vanity—which was, if the truth be known, a little difficult to deal with. One day, for instance, when she was speaking of her four thorns, she said to the little prince:

"Let the tigers come with their claws!"

"There are no tigers on my planet," the little prince objected. "And, anyway, tigers do not eat weeds."

"I am not a weed," the flower replied, sweetly.

"Please excuse me..."

"I am not at all afraid of tigers," she went on, "but I have a horror of drafts. I suppose you wouldn't have a screen for me?"

"A horror of drafts—that is bad luck, for a plant," remarked the little prince, and added to himself, "This flower is a very complex creature..."

"At night I want you to put me under a glass globe. It is very cold where you live. In the place I came from—"

But she interrupted herself at that point. She had come in the form of a seed. She could not have known anything of any other worlds. Embarassed over having let herself be caught on the verge of such a naive untruth, she coughed two or three times, in order to put the little prince in the wrong.

"The screen?"

"I was just going to look for it when you spoke to me..."

Then she forced her cough a little more so that he should suffer from remorse just the same. So the little prince, in spite of all the good will that was inseparable from his love, had soon come to doubt her. He had taken seriously words which were without importance, and it made him very unhappy.

"I ought not to have listened to her," he confided to me one day. "One never ought to listen to the flowers. One should simply look at them and breathe their fragrance. Mine perfumed all my planet. But I did not know how to take pleasure in all her grace. This tale of claws, which disturbed me so much, should only have filled my heart with tenderness and pity."

And he continued his confidences:

"The fact is that I did not know how to understand anything! I ought to have judged by deeds and not by words. She cast her fragrance and her radiance over me. I ought never to have run away from her... I ought to have guessed all the affection that lay

behind her poor little strategems. Flowers are so inconsistent! But I was too young to know how to love her..."

IX

I believe that for his escape he took advantage of the migration of a flock of wild birds. On the morning of his departure he put his planet in perfect order. He carefully cleaned out his active volcanoes. He possessed two active volcanoes; and they were very convenient for heating his breakfast in the morning. He also had one volcano that was extinct. But, as he said, "One never knows!" So he cleaned out the extinct volcano, too. If they are well cleaned out, volcanoes burn slowly and steadily, without any eruptions. Volcanic eruptions are like fires in a chimney.

On our earth we are obviously much too small to clean out our volcanoes. That is why they bring no end of trouble upon us. The little prince also pulled up, with a certain sense of dejection, the last little shoots of the baobabs. He believed that he would never want to return. But on this last morning all these familiar

tasks seemed very precious to him. And when he watered the flower for the last time, and prepared to place her under the shelter of her glass globe, he realized that he was very close to tears.

"Goodbye," he said to the flower.

But she made no answer.

"Goodbye," he said again.

The flower coughed. But it was not because she had a cold.

"I have been silly," she said to him, at last. "I ask your forgiveness. Try to be happy..."

He was surprised by this absence of reproaches. He stood there all bewildered, the glass globe held arrested in mid-air. He did not understand this quiet sweetness.

"Of course I love you," the flower said to him. "It is my fault that you have not known it all the while. That is of no importance.

But you—you have been just as foolish as I. Try to be happy... Let the glass globe be. I don't want it any more."

"But the wind—"

"My cold is not so bad as all that... The cool night air will do me good. I am a flower."

"But the animals—"

"Well, I must endure the presence of two or three caterpillars if I wish to become acquainted with the butterflies. It seems that they are very beautiful. And if not the butterflies—and the caterpillars—who will call upon me? You will be far away... As for the large animals—I am not at all afraid of any of them. I have my claws."

And, naively, she showed her four thorns. Then she added:

"Don't linger like this. You have decided to go away. Now go!"

For she did not want him to see her crying. She was such a proud flower.

X

He found himself in the neighborhood of the asteroids 325, 326, 327, 328, 329, and 330. He began, therefore, by visiting them, in order to add to his knowledge.

The first of them was inhabited by a king. Clad in royal purple and ermine, he was seated upon a throne which was at the same time both simple and majestic.

"Ah! Here is a subject," exclaimed the king, when he saw the little prince coming.

And the little prince asked himself:

"How could he recognize me when he had never seen me before?"

He did not know how the world is simplified for kings. To them, all men are subjects.

"Approach, so that I may see you better," said the king, who

felt consumingly proud of being at last a king over somebody.

The little prince looked everywhere to find a place to sit down; but the entire planet was crammed and obstructed by the king's magnificent ermine robe. So he remained standing upright, and, since he was tired, he yawned.

"It is contrary to etiquette to yawn in the presence of a king," the monarch said to him. "I forbid you to do so."

"I can't help it. I can't stop myself," replied the little prince, thoroughly embarrassed. "I have come on a long journey, and I have had no sleep..."

"Ah, then," the king said. "I order you to yawn. It is years since I have seen anyone yawning. Yawns, to me, are objects of curiosity. Come, now! Yawn again! It is an order."

"That frightens me... I cannot, any more..." murmured the little prince, now completely abashed.

"Hum! Hum!" replied the king. "Then I—I order you sometimes to yawn and sometimes to—"

He sputtered a little, and seemed vexed.

For what the king fundamentally insisted upon was that his authority should be respected. He tolerated no disobedience. He was an absolute monarch. But, because he was a very good man, he made his orders reasonable.

"If I ordered a general," he would say, by way of example, "if I ordered a general to change himself into a sea bird, and if the general did not obey me, that would not be the fault of the general. It would be my fault."

"May I sit down?" came now a timid inquiry from the little prince.

"I order you to do so," the king answered him, and majestically gathered in a fold of his ermine mantle.

But the little prince was wondering... The planet was tiny. Over what could this king really rule?

"Sire," he said to him, "I beg that you will excuse my asking you a question—"

"I order you to ask me a question," the king hastened to assure him.

"Sire—over what do you rule?"

"Over everything," said the king, with magnificent simplicity.

"Over everything?"

The king made a gesture, which took in his planet, the other planets, and all the stars.

"Over all that?" asked the little prince.

"Over all that," the king answered.

For his rule was not only absolute: it was also universal.

"And the stars obey you?"

"Certainly they do," the king said. "They obey instantly. I do not permit insubordination."

Such power was a thing for the little prince to marvel at. If he had been master of such complete authority, he would have been able to watch the sunset, not forty-four times in one day, but seventy-two, or even a hundred, or even two hundred times, without ever having to move his chair. And because he felt a bit sad as he remembered his little planet which he had forsaken, he plucked up his courage to ask the king a favor:

"I should like to see a sunset... Do me that kindness... Order the sun to set..."

"If I ordered a general to fly from one flower to another like a butterfly, or to write a tragic drama, or to change himself into a sea bird, and if the general did not carry out the order that he had received, which one of us would be in the wrong?" the king demanded. "The general, or myself?"

"You," said the little prince firmly.

"Exactly. One must require from each one the duty which each one can perform," the king went on. "Accepted authority rests first of all on reason. If you ordered your people to go and throw themselves into the sea, they would rise up in revolution. I have the right to require obedience because my orders are reasonable."

"Then my sunset?" the little prince reminded him: for he never forgot a question once he had asked it.

"You shall have your sunset. I shall command it. But, according to my science of government, I shall wait until conditions are favorable."

"When will that be?" inquired the little prince.

"Hum! Hum!" replied the king; and before saying anything else he consulted a bulky almanac. "Hum! Hum! That will be about—about—that will be this evening about twenty minutes to eight. And you will see how well I am obeyed!"

The little prince yawned. He was regretting his lost sunset.

And then, too, he was already beginning to be a little bored.

"I have nothing more to do here," he said to the king. "So I shall set out on my way again."

"Do not go," said the king, who was very proud of having a subject. "Do not go. I will make you a minister!"

"Minister of what?"

"Minster of—of Justice!"

"But there is nobody here to judge!"

"We do not know that," the king said to him. "I have not yet made a complete tour of my kingdom. I am very old. There is no room here for a carriage. And it tires me to walk."

"Oh, but I have looked already!" said the little prince, turning around to give one more glance to the other side of the planet. On that side, as on this, there was nobody at all...

"Then you shall judge yourself," the king answered. "that is the most difficult thing of all. It is much more difficult to judge oneself than to judge others. If you succeed in judging yourself rightly, then you are indeed a man of true wisdom."

"Yes," said the little prince, "but I can judge myself anywhere. I do not need to live on this planet."

"Hum! Hum!" said the king. "I have good reason to believe that somewhere on my planet there is an old rat. I hear him at night. You can judge this old rat. From time to time you will condemn him to death. Thus his life will depend on your justice. But you will pardon him on each occasion; for he must be treated

thriftily. He is the only one we have."

"I," replied the little prince, "do not like to condemn anyone to death. And now I think I will go on my way."

"No," said the king.

But the little prince, having now completed his preparations for departure, had no wish to grieve the old monarch.

"If Your Majesty wishes to be promptly obeyed," he said, "he should be able to give me a reasonable order. He should be able, for example, to order me to be gone by the end of one minute. It seems to me that conditions are favorable..."

As the king made no answer, the little prince hesitated a moment. Then, with a sigh, he took his leave.

"I make you my ambassador," the king called out, hastily.

He had a magnificent air of authority.

"The grown-ups are very strange," the little prince said to himself, as he continued on his journey.

XI

The second planet was inhabited by a conceited man.

"Ah! Ah! I am about to receive a visit from an admirer!" he exclaimed from afar, when he first saw the little prince coming. For, to conceited men, all other men are admirers.

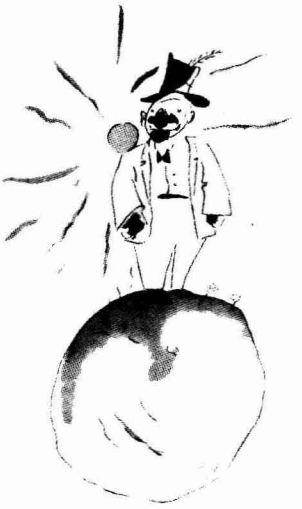
"Good morning," said the little prince. "That is a queer hat you are wearing."

"It is a hat for salutes," the conceited man replied. "It is to raise in salute when people acclaim me. Unfortunately, nobody at all ever passes this way."

"Yes?" said the little prince, who did not understand what the conceited man was talking about.

"Clap your hands, one against the other," the conceited man now directed him.

The little prince clapped his hands. The conceited man raised



his hat in a modest salute.

"This is more entertaining than the visit to the king," the little prince said to himself. And he began again to clap his hands, one against the other. The conceited man again raised his hat in salute.

After five minutes of this exercise the little prince grew tired of the game's monotony.

"And what should one do to make the hat come down?" he asked.

But the conceited man did not hear him. Conceited people never hear anything but praise.

"Do you really admire me very much?" he demanded of the little prince.

"What does that mean—'admire'?"

"To admire means that you regard me as the handsomest, the best-dressed, the richest, and the most intelligent man on this planet."

"But you are the only man on your planet!"

"Do me this kindness. Admire me just the same."

"I admire you," said the little prince, shrugging his shoulders slightly, "but what is there in that to interest you so much?"

And the little prince went away.

"The grown-ups are certainly very odd," he said to himself, as he continued on his journey.

XII

The next planet was inhabited by a tippler. This was a very short visit, but it plunged the little prince into deep dejection.

"What are you doing there?" he said to the tippler, whom he found settled down in silence before a collection of empty bottles and also a collection of full bottles.

"I am drinking," replied the tippler, with a lugubrious air.

"Why are you drinking?" demanded the little prince.

"So that I may forget," replied the tippler.

"Forget what?" inquired the little prince, who already was sorry for him.

"Forget that I am ashamed," the tippler confessed, hanging his head.

"Ashamed of what?" insisted the little prince, who wanted to help him.

"Ashamed of drinking!" The tippler brought his speech to an end, and shut himself up in an impregnable silence.

And the little prince went away, puzzled.

"The grown-ups are certainly very, very odd," he said to himself, as he continued on his journey.

XIII

The fourth planet belonged to a businessman. This man was so much occupied that he did not even raise his head at the little prince's arrival.

"Good morning," the little prince said to him. "Your cigarette has gone out."

"Three and two make five. Five and seven make twelve. Twelve and three make fifteen. Good morning. Fifteen and seven make twenty-two. Twenty-two and six make twenty-eight. I haven't time to light it again. Twenty-six and five make thirty-one. Phew! Then that makes five-hundred-and-one million, six-hundred-twenty-two-thousand, seven-hundred-thirty-one."

"Five hundred million what?" asked the little prince.

"Eh? Are you still there? Five-hundred-and-one million—I can't stop... I have so much to do! I am concerned with matters of consequence. I don't amuse myself with balderdash. Two and five make seven..."

"Five-hundred-and-one million what?" repeated the little prince, who never in his life had let go of a question once he had asked it.

The businessman raised his head.

"During the fifty-four years that I have inhabited this planet, I have been disturbed only three times. The first time was twenty-two years ago, when some giddy goose fell from goodness knows where. He made the most frightful noise that resounded all over the place, and I made four mistakes in my addition. The second time, eleven years ago, I was disturbed by an attack of rheumatism. I don't get enough exercise. I have no time for loafing. The third time—well, this is it! I was saying, then,

five-hundred-and-one millions—"

"Millions of what?"

The businessman suddenly realized that there was no hope of being left in peace until he answered this question.

"Millions of those little objects," he said, "which one sometimes sees in the sky."

"Flies?"

"Oh, no. Little glittering objects."

"Bees?"

"Oh, no. Little golden objects that set lazy men to idle dreaming. As for me, I am concerned with matters of consquence. There is no time for idle dreaming in my life."

"Ah! You mean the stars?"

"Yes, that's it. The stars."

"And what do you do with five-hundred millions of stars?"

"Five-hundred-and-one million, six-hundred-twenty-two thousand, seven-hundred-thirty-one. I am concerned with matters of consequence: I am accurate."

"And what do you do with these stars?"

"What do I do with them?"

"Yes."

"Nothing. I own them."

"You own the stars?"

"Yes."

"But I have already seen a king who—"

"Kings do not own, they reign over. It is a very different matter."

"And what good does it do you to own the stars?"

"It does me the good of making me rich."

"And what good does it do you to be rich?"

"It makes it possible for me to buy more stars, if any are discovered."

"This man," the little prince said to himself, "reasons a little like my poor tippler..."

Nevertheless, he still had some more questions.

"How is it possible for one to own the stars?"

"To whom do they belong?" the businessman retorted, peevishly.

"I don't know. To nobody."

"Then they belong to me, because I was the first person to think of it."

"Is that all that is necessary?"

"Certainly. When you find a diamond that belongs to nobody, it is yours. When you discover an island that belongs to nobody, it is yours. When you get an idea before any one else, you take out a patent on it: it is yours. So with me: I own the stars, because nobody else before me ever thought of owning them."

"Yes, that is true," said the little prince. "And what do you do with them?"

"I administer them," replied the businessman. "I count them

and recount them. It is difficult. But I am a man who is naturally interested in matters of consequence."

The little prince was still not satisfied.

"If I owned a silk scarf," he said, "I could put it around my neck and take it away with me. If I owned a flower, I could pluck that flower and take it away with me. But you cannot pluck the stars from heaven..."

"No. But I can put them in the bank."

"Whatever does that mean?"

"That means that I write the number of my stars on a little paper. And then I put this paper in a drawer and lock it with a key."

"And that is all?"

"That is enough," said the businessman.

"It is entertaining," thought the little prince. "It is rather poetic. But it is of no great consequence."

On matters of consequence, the little prince had ideas which were very different from those of the grown-ups.

"I myself own a flower," he continued his conversation with the businessman, "which I water every day. I own three volcanoes, which I clean out every week (for I also clean out the one that is extinct; one never knows). It is of some use to my volcanoes, and it is of some use to my flower, that I own them. But you are of no use to the stars..."

The businessman opened his mouth, but he found nothing to

say in answer. And the little prince went away.

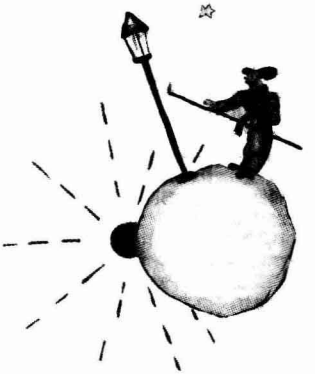
"The grown-ups are certainly altogether extraordinary," he said simply, talking to himself as he continued on his journey.

XIV

The fifth planet was very strange. It was the smallest of all. There was just enough room on it for a street lamp and a lamplighter. The little prince was not able to reach any explanation of the use of a street lamp and a lamplighter, somewhere in the heavens, on a planet which had no people, and not one house. But he said to himself, nevertheless:

"It may well be that this man is absurd. But he is not so absurd as the king, the conceited man, the businessman, and the tippler. For at least his work has some meaning. When he lights his street lamp, it is as if he brought one more star to life, or one flower. When he puts out his lamp, he sends the flower, or the star, to sleep. That is a beautiful occupation. And since it is beautiful, it is truly useful."

When he arrived on the planet he respectfully saluted the



lamplighter.

"Good morning. Why have you just put out your lamp?"

"Those are the orders," replied the lamplighter. "Good morning."

"What are the orders?"

"The orders are that I put out my lamp. Good evening."

And he lighted his lamp again.

"But why have you just lighted it again?"

"Those are the orders," replied the lamplighter.

"I do not understand," said the little prince.

"There is nothing to understand," said the lamplighter. "Orders are orders. Good morning."

And he put out his lamp. Then he mopped his forehead with a handkerchief decorated with red squares.

"I follow a terrible profession. In the old days it was reasonable. I put the lamp out in the morning, and in the evening I lighted it again. I had the rest of the day for relaxation and the rest of the night for sleep."

"And the orders have been changed since that time?"

"The orders have not been changed," said the lamplighter. "That is the tragedy! From year to year the planet has turned more rapidly and the orders have not been changed!"

"Then what?" asked the little prince.

"Then—the planet now makes a complete turn every minute, and I no longer have a single second for repose. Once every minute I have to light my lamp and put it out!"

"That is very funny! A day lasts only one minute, here where you live!"

"It is not funny at all!" said the lamplighter. "While we have been talking together a month has gone by."

"A month?"

"Yes, a month. Thirty minutes. Thirty days. Good evening."

And he lighted his lamp again. As the little prince watched him, he felt that he loved this lamplighter who was so faithful to his orders. He remembered the sunsets which he himself had gone to seek, in other days, merely by pulling up his chair; and he wanted to help his friend.

"You know," he said, "I can tell you a way you can rest whenever you want to..."

"I always want to rest," said the lamplighter.

For it is possible for a man to be faithful and lazy at the same time. The little prince went on with his explanation:

"Your planet is so small that three strides will take you all the way around it. To be always in the sunshine, you need only walk along rather slowly. When you want to rest, you will walk—and the day will last as long as you like."

"That doesn't do me much good," said the lamplighter. "The one thing I love in life is to sleep."

"Then you're unlucky," said the little prince.

"I am unlucky," said the lamplighter. "Good morning."

And he put out his lamp.

"That man," said the little prince to himself, as he continued farther on his journey, "that man would be scorned by all the others: by the king, by the conceited man, by the tippler, by the businessman. Nevertheless he is the only one of them all who does not seem to me ridiculous. Perhaps that is because he is thinking of something else besides himself."

He breathed a sigh of regret, and said to himself, again:

"That man is the only one of them all whom I could have made my friend. But his planet is indeed too small. There is no room on it for two people..."

What the little prince did not dare confess was that he was sorry most of all to leave this planet, because it was blest every day with 1440 sunsets!

XV

The sixth planet was ten times larger than the last one. It was inhabited by an old gentleman who wrote voluminous books.

"Oh, look! Here is an explorer!" he exclaimed to himself when he saw the little prince coming.

The little prince sat down on the table and panted a little. He had already traveled so much and so far!

"Where do you come from?" the old gentleman said to him.

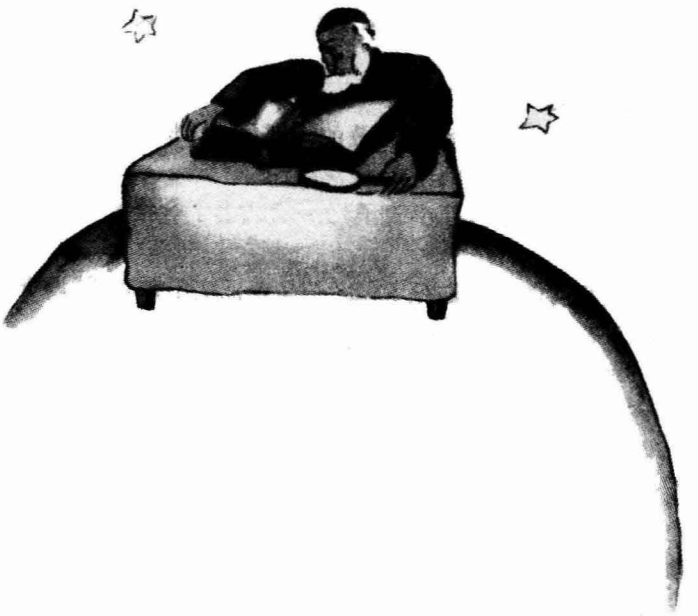
"What is that big book?" said the little prince. "What are you doing?"

"I am a geographer," said the old gentleman.

"What is a geographer?" asked the little prince.

"A geographer is a scholar who knows the location of all the seas, rivers, towns, mountains, and deserts."

"That is very interesting," said the little prince. "Here at last



is a man who has a real profession!" And he cast a look around him at the planet of the geographer. It was the most magnificent and stately planet that he had ever seen.

"Your planet is very beautiful," he said. "Has it any oceans?"

"I couldn't tell you," said the geographer.

"Ah!" The little prince was disappointed. "Has it any mountains?"

"I couldn't tell you," said the geographer.

"And towns, and rivers, and deserts?"

"I couldn't tell you that, either."

"But you are a geographer!"

"Exactly," the geographer said. "But I am not an explorer. I haven't a single explorer on my planet. It is not the geographer who goes out to count the towns, the rivers, the mountains, the seas, the oceans, and the deserts. The geographer is much too important to go loafing about. He does not leave his desk. But he receives the explorers in his study. He asks them questions, and he notes down what they recall of their travels. And if the recollections of any one among them seem interesting to him, the geographer orders an inquiry into that explorer's moral character."

"Why is that?"

"Because an explorer who told lies would bring disaster on the books of the geographer. So would an explorer who drank too much."

"Why is that?" asked the little prince.

"Because intoxicated men see double. Then the geographer would note down two mountains in a place where there was only one."

"I know some one," said the little prince, "who would make a bad explorer."

"That is possible. Then, when the moral character of the explorer is shown to be good, an inquiry is ordered into his discovery."

"One goes to see it?"

"No. That would be too complicated. But one requires the

explorer to furnish proofs. For example, if the discovery in question is that of a large mountain, one requires that large stones be brought back from it."

The geographer was suddenly stirred to excitement.

"But you—you come from far away! You are an explorer! You shall describe your planet to me!"

And, having opened his big register, the geographer sharpened his pencil. The recitals of explorers are put down first in pencil. One waits until the explorer has furnished proofs, before putting them down in ink.

"Well?" said the geographer expectantly.

"Oh, where I live," said the little prince, "it is not very interesting. It is all so small. I have three volcanoes. Two volcanoes are active and the other is extinct. But one never knows."

"One never knows," said the geographer.

"I have also a flower."

"We do not record flowers," said the geographer.

"Why is that? The flower is the most beautiful thing on my planet!"

"We do not record them," said the geographer, "because they are ephemeral."

"What does that mean—'ephemeral'?"

"Geographies," said the geographer, "are the books which, of all books, are most concerned with matters of consequence. They never become old-fashioned. It is very rarely that a mountain

changes its position. It is very rarely that an ocean empties itself of its waters. We write of eternal things."

"But extinct volcanoes may come to life again," the little prince interrupted. "What does that mean—'ephemeral'?"

"Whether volcanoes are extinct or alive, it comes to the same thing for us," said the geographer. "The thing that matters to us is the mountain. It does not change."

"But what does that mean—'ephemeral'?" repeated the little prince, who never in his life had let go of a question, once he had asked it.

"It means, 'which is in danger of speedy disappearance.'"

"Is my flower in danger of speedy disappearance?"

"Certainly it is."

"My flower is ephemeral," the little prince said to himself, "and she has only four thorns to defend herself against the world. And I have left her on my planet, all alone!"

That was his first moment of regret. But he took courage once more.

"What place would you advise me to visit now?" he asked.

"The planet Earth," replied the geographer. "It has a good reputation."

And the little prince went away, thinking of his flower.

XVI

So then the seventh planet was the Earth.

The Earth is not just an ordinary planet! One can count, there, 111 kings (not forgetting, to be sure, the Negro kings among them), 7000 geographers, 900,000 businessmen, 7,500,000 tipplers, 311,000,000 conceited men—that is to say, about 2,000,000,000 grown-ups.

To give you an idea of the size of the Earth, I will tell you that before the invention of electricity it was necessary to maintain, over the whole of the six continents, a veritable army of 462,511 lamplighters for the street lamps. Seen from a slight distance, that would make a splendid spectacle. The movements of this army would be regulated like those of the ballet in the opera. First would come the turn of the lamplighters of New Zealand and Australia. Having set their lamps alight, these would go off to

sleep. Next, the lamplighters of China and Siberia would enter for their steps in the dance, and then they too would be waved back into the wings. After that would come the turn of the lamplighters of Russia and the Indies; then those of Africa and Europe; then those of South America; then those of South America; then those of North America. And never would they make a mistake in the order of their entry upon the stage. It would be magnificent.

Only the man who was in charge of the single lamp at the North Pole, and his colleague who was responsible for the single lamp at the South Pole—only these two would live free from toil and care: they would be busy twice a year.

XVII

When one wishes to play the wit, he sometimes wanders a little from the truth. I have not been altogether honest in what I have told you about the lamplighters. And I realize that I run the risk of giving a false idea of our planet to those who do not know it. Men occupy a very small place upon the Earth. If the two billion inhabitants who people its surface were all to stand upright and somewhat crowded together, as they do for some big public assembly, they could easily be put into one public square twenty miles long and twenty miles wide. All humanity could be piled up on a small Pacific islet.

The grown-ups, to be sure, will not believe you when you tell them that. They imagine that they fill a great deal of space. They fancy themselves as important as the baobabs. You should advise them, then, to make their own calculations. They adore figures,

and that will please them. But do not waste your time on this extra task. It is unnecessary. You have, I know, confidence in me.

When the little prince arrived on the Earth, he was very much surprised not to see any people. He was beginning to be afraid he had come to the wrong planet, when a coil of gold, the color of the moonlight, flashed across the sand.

"Good evening," said the little prince courteously.

"Good evening," said the snake.

"What planet is this on which I have come down?" asked the little prince.

"This is the Earth; this is Africa," the snake answered.

"Ah! Then there are no people on the Earth?"

"This is the desert. There are no people in the desert. The Earth is large," said the snake.

The little prince sat down on a stone, and raised his eyes toward the sky.

"I wonder," he said, "whether the stars are set alight in heaven so that one day each one of us may find his own again... Look at my planet. It is right there above us. But how far away it is!"

"It is beautiful," the snake said. "What has brought you here?"

"I have been having some trouble with a flower," said the little prince.

"Ah!" said the snake.

And they were both silent.

"Where are the men?" the little prince at last took up the

conversation again. "It is a little lonely in the desert..."

"It is also lonely among men," the snake said.

The little prince gazed at him for a long time.

"You are a funny animal," he said at last. "You are no thicker than a finger..."

"But I am more powerful than the finger of a king," said the snake.

The little prince smiled.

"You are not very powerful. You haven't even any feet. You cannot even travel..."

"I can carry you farther than any ship could take you," said the snake.

He twined himself around the little prince's ankle, like a golden bracelet.

"Whomever I touch, I send back to the earth from whence he came," the snake spoke again. "But you are innocent and true, and you come from a star..."

The little prince made no reply.

"You move me to pity—you are so weak on this Earth made of granite," the snake said. "I can help you, some day, if you grow too homesick for your own planet. I can—"

"Oh! I understand you very well," said the little prince. "But why do you always speak in riddles?"

"I solve them all," said the snake.

And they were both silent.

XVIII

The little prince crossed the desert and met with only one flower. It was a flower with three petals, a flower of no account at all.

"Good morning," said the little prince.

"Good morning," said the flower.

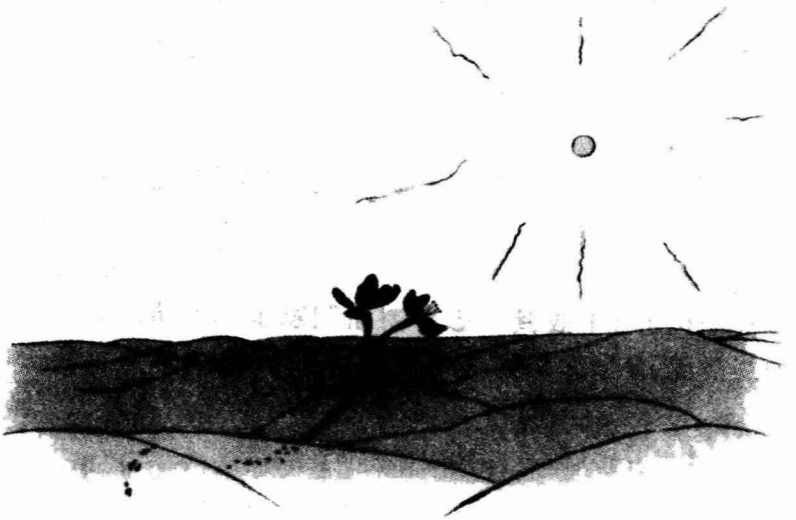
"Where are the men?" the little prince asked, politely.

The flower had once seen a caravan passing.

"Men?" she echoed. "I think there are six or seven of them in existence. I saw them, several years ago. But one never knows where to find them. The wind blows them away. They have no roots, and that makes their life very difficult."

"Goodbye," said the little prince.

"Goodbye," said the flower.



XIX

After that, the little prince climbed a high mountain. The only mountains he had ever known were the three volcanoes, which came up to his knees. And he used the extinct volcano as a footstool. "From a mountain as high as this one," he said to himself, "I shall be able to see the whole planet at one glance, and all the people..."

But he saw nothing, save peaks of rock that were sharpened like needles.

"Good morning," he said courteously.

"Good morning—Good morning—Good morning," answered the echo.

"Who are you?" said the little prince.

"Who are you—Who are you—Who are you?" answered the echo.

"Be my friends. I am all alone," he said.

"I am all alone—all alone—all alone," answered the echo.

"What a queer planet!" he thought. "It is altogether dry, and altogether pointed, and altogether harsh and forbidding. And the people have no imagination. They repeat whatever one says to them... On my planet I had a flower; she always was the first to speak..."

XX

But it happened that after walking for a long time through sand, and rocks, and snow, the little prince at last came upon a road. And all roads lead to the abodes of men.

"Good morning," he said.

He was standing before a garden, all abloom with roses.

"Good morning," said the roses.

The little prince gazed at them. They all looked like his flower.

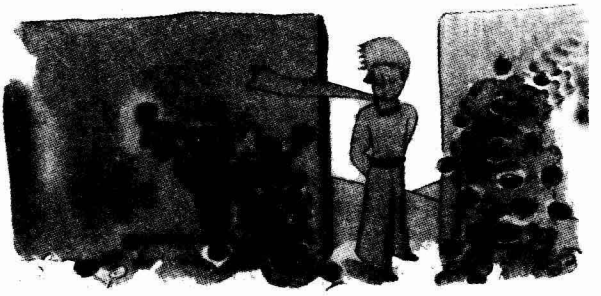
"Who are you?" he demanded, thunderstruck.

"We are roses," the roses said.

And he was overcome with sadness. His flower had told him that she was the only one of her kind in all the universe. And here were five thousand of them, all alike, in one single garden!

"She would be very much annoyed," he said to himself, "if

she should see that... She would cough most dreadfully, and she would pretend that she was dying, to avoid being laughed at. And I should be obliged to pretend that I was nursing her back to life—for if I did not do that, to humble myself also, she would really allow herself to die..."



Then he went on with his reflections: "I thought that I was rich, with a flower that was unique in all the world; and all I had was a common rose. A common rose, and three volcanoes that come up to my knees—and one of them perhaps extinct forever... That doesn't make me a very great prince..."

And he lay down in the grass and cried.

XXI

It was then that the fox appeared.

"Good morning," said the fox.

"Good morning," the little prince responded politely, although when he turned around he saw nothing.

"I am right here," the voice said, "under the apple tree."

"Who are you?" asked the little prince, and added, "You are very pretty to look at."

"I am a fox," the fox said.

"Come and play with me," proposed the little prince. "I am so unhappy."

"I cannot play with you," the fox said. "I am not tamed."

"Ah! Please excuse me," said the little prince.

But, after some thought, he added:

"What does that mean—'tame'?"

"You do not live here," said the fox. "What is it that you are looking for?"

"I am looking for men," said the little prince. "What does that mean—'tame'?"

"Men," said the fox. "They have guns, and they hunt. It is very disturbing. They also raise chickens. These are their only interests. Are you looking for chickens?"

"No," said the little prince. "I am looking for friends. What does that mean—'tame'?"

"It is an act too often neglected," said the fox. "It means to establish ties."

"'To establish ties'?"

"Just that," said the fox. "To me, you are still nothing more than a little boy who is just like a hundred thousand other little boys. And I have no need of you. And you, on your part, have no need of me. To you, I am nothing more than a fox like a hundred

thousand other foxes. But if you tame me, then we shall need each other. To me, you will be unique in all the world. To you, I shall be unique in all the world..."

"I am beginning to understand," said the little prince. "There is a flower... I think that she has tamed me..."

"It is possible," said the fox. "On the Earth one sees all sorts of things."

"Oh, but this is not on the Earth!" said the little prince.

The fox seemed perplexed, and very curious.

"On another planet?"

"Yes."

"Are there hunters on that planet?"

"No."

"Ah, that is interesting! Are there chickens?"

"No."

"Nothing is perfect," sighed the fox.

But he came back to his idea.

"My life is very monotonous," the fox said. "I hunt chickens; men hunt me. All the chickens are just alike, and all the men are just alike. And, in consequence, I am a little bored. But if you tame me, it will be as if the sun came to shine on my life. I shall know the sound of a step that will be different from all the others. Other steps send me hurrying back underneath the ground. Yours will call me, like music, out of my burrow. And then look: you see the grain-fields down yonder? I do not eat bread. Wheat is of no use to me. The wheat fields have nothing to say to me. And that is sad. But you have hair that is the color of gold. Think how wonderful that will be when you have tamed me! The grain, which is also golden, will bring me back the thought of you. And I shall love to listen to the wind in the wheat..."

The fox gazed at the little prince, for a long time.

"Please—tame me!" he said.

"I want to, very much," the little prince replied. "But I have not much time. I have friends to discover, and a great many things to understand."

"One only understands the things that one tames," said the fox. "Men have no more time to understand anything. They buy things all ready made at the shops. But there is no shop anywhere where one can buy friendship, and so men have no friends any

more. If you want a friend, tame me..."

"What must I do, to tame you?" asked the little prince.

"You must be very patient," replied the fox. "First you will sit down at a little distance from me—like that—in the grass. I shall look at you out of the corner of my eye, and you will say nothing. Words are the source of misunderstandings. But you will sit a little closer to me, every day..."

The next day the little prince came back.

"It would have been better to come back at the same hour," said the fox. "If, for example, you come at four o'clock in the afternoon, then at three o'clock I shall begin to be happy. I shall feel happier and happier as the hour advances. At four o'clock, I shall already be worrying and jumping about. I shall show you how happy I am! But if you come at just any time, I shall never know at what hour my heart is to be ready to greet you... One must

observe the proper rites..."

"What is a rite?" asked the little prince.

"Those also are actions too often neglected," said the fox. "They are what make one day different from other days, one hour from other hours. There is a rite, for example, among my hunters. Every Thursday they dance with the village girls. So Thursday is a wonderful day for me! I can take a walk as far as the vineyards. But if the hunters danced at just any time, every day would be like every other day, and I should never have any vacation at all."

So the little prince tamed the fox. And when the hour of his departure drew near—

"Ah," said the fox, "I shall cry."

"It is your own fault," said the little prince. "I never wished you any sort of harm; but you wanted me to tame you..."

"Yes, that is so," said the fox.

"But now you are going to cry!" said the little prince.

"Yes, that is so," said the fox.

"Then it has done you no good at all!"

"It has done me good," said the fox, "because of the color of the wheat fields." And then he added:

"Go and look again at the roses. You will understand now that yours is unique in all the world. Then come back to say good-bye to me, and I will make you a present of a secret."

The little prince went away, to look again at the roses.

"You are not at all like my rose," he said. "As yet you are

nothing. No one has tamed you, and you have tamed no one. You are like my fox when I first knew him. He was only a fox like a hundred thousand other foxes. But I have made him my friend, and now he is unique in all the world."

And the roses were very much embarassed.

"You are beautiful, but you are empty," he went on. "One could not die for you. To be sure, an ordinary passerby would think that my rose looked just like you—the rose that belongs to me. But in herself alone she is more important than all the hundreds of you other roses: because it is she that I have watered; because it is she that I have put under the glass globe; because it is she that I have sheltered behind the screen; because it is for her that I have killed the caterpillars (except the two or three that we saved to become butterflies); because it is she that I have listened to, when she grumbled, or boasted, or ever sometimes when she said nothing. Because she is my rose."

And he went back to meet the fox.

"Goodbye," he said.

"Goodbye," said the fox. "And now here is my secret, a very simple secret: It is only with the heart that one can see rightly; what is essential is invisible to the eye."

"What is essential is invisible to the eye," the little prince repeated, so that he would be sure to remember.

"It is the time you have wasted for your rose that makes your rose so important."

"It is the time I have wasted for my rose—" said the little prince, so that he would be sure to remember.

"Men have forgotten this truth," said the fox. "But you must not forget it. You become responsible, forever, for what you have tamed. You are responsible for your rose..."

"I am responsible for my rose," the little prince repeated, so that he would be sure to remember.

XXII

"Good morning," said the little prince.

"Good morning", said the railway switchman.

"What do you do here?" the little prince asked.

"I sort out travelers, in bundles of a thousand", said the switchman. "I send off the trains that carry them: now to the right, now to the left."

And a brilliantly lighted express train shook the switchman's cabin as it rushed by with a roar like thunder.

"They are in a great hurry," said the little prince. "What are they looking for?"

"Not even the locomotive engineer knows that," said the switchman.

And a second brilliantly lighted express thundered by, in the opposite direction.

"Are they coming back already?" demanded the little prince.

"These are not the same ones," said the switchman. "It is an exchange."

"Were they not satisfied where they were?" asked the little prince.

"No one is ever satisfied where he is," said the switchman.

And they heard the roaring thunder of a third brilliantly lighted express.

"Are they pursuing the first travelers?" demanded the little prince.

"They are pursuing nothing at all," said the switchman. "They are asleep in there, or if they are not asleep they are yawning. Only the children are flattening their noses against the windowpanes."

"Only the children know what they are looking for," said the little prince. "They waste their time over a rag doll and it becomes very important to them; and if anybody takes it away from them, they cry..."

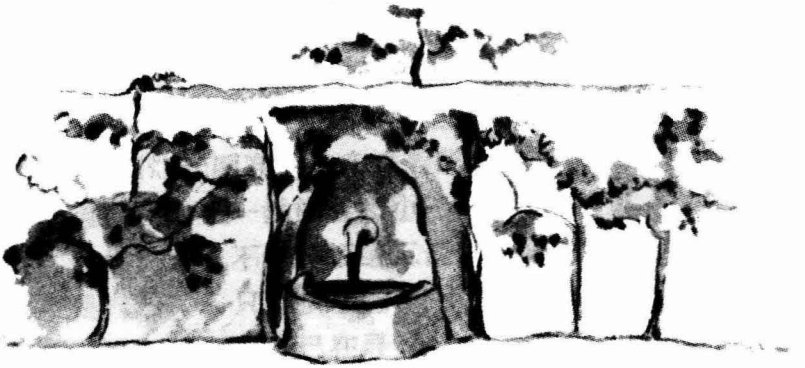
"They are lucky," the switchman said.

XXIII

"Good morning," said the little prince.

"Good morning," said the merchant.

This was a merchant who sold pills that had been invented to quench thirst. You need only swallow one pill a week, and you



would feel no need of anything to drink.

"Why are you selling those?" asked the little prince.

"Because they save a tremendous amount of time," said the merchant. "Computations have been made by experts. With these pills, you save fifty-three minutes in every week."

"And what do I do with those fifty-three minutes?"

"Anything you like..."

"As for me," said the little prince to himself, "if I had fifty-three minutes to spend as I liked, I should walk at my leisure toward a spring of fresh water."

XXIV

It was now the eighth day since I had had my accident in the desert, and I had listened to the story of the merchant as I was drinking the last drop of my water supply.

"Ah," I said to the little prince, "these memories of yours are very charming; but I have not yet succeeded in repairing my plane; I have nothing more to drink; and I, too, should be very happy if I could walk at my leisure toward a spring of fresh water!"

"My friend the fox—" the little prince said to me.

"My dear little man, this is no longer a matter that has anything to do with the fox!"

"Why not?"

"Because I am about to die of thirst..."

He did not follow my reasoning, and he answered me:

"It is a good thing to have had a friend, even if one is about to die. I, for instance, am very glad to have had a fox as a friend..."

"He has no way of guessing the danger," I said to myself. "He has never been either hungry or thirsty. A little sunshine is all he needs..."

But he looked at me steadily, and replied to my thought:

"I am thirsty, too. Let us look for a well..."

I made a gesture of weariness. It is absurd to look for a well, at random, in the immensity of the desert. But nevertheless we started walking.

When we had trudged along for several hours, in silence, the darkness fell, and the stars began to come out. Thirst had made me a little feverish, and I looked at them as if I were in a dream. The little prince's last words came reeling back into my memory:

"Then you are thirsty, too?" I demanded.

But he did not reply to my question. He merely said to me:

"Water may also be good for the heart..."

I did not understand this answer, but I said nothing. I knew very well that it was impossible to cross-examine him. He was tired. He sat down. I sat down beside him. And, after a little silence, he spoke again:

"The stars are beautiful, because of a flower that cannot be seen."

I replied, "Yes, that is so." And, without saying anything more, I looked across the ridges of sand that were stretched out

before us in the moonlight.

"The desert is beautiful," the little prince added.

And that was true. I have always loved the desert. One sits down on a desert sand dune, sees nothing, hears nothing. Yet through the silence something throbs, and gleams...

"What makes the desert beautiful," said the little prince, "is that somewhere it hides a well..."

I was astonished by a sudden understanding of that mysterious radiation of the sands. When I was a little boy I lived in an old house, and legend told us that a treasure was buried there. To be sure, no one had ever known how to find it; perhaps no one had ever even looked for it. But it cast an enchantment over that house. My home was hiding a secret in the depths of its heart...

"Yes," I said to the little prince. "The house, the stars, the desert—what gives them their beauty is something that is invisible!"

"I am glad," he said, "that you agree with my fox."

As the little prince dropped off to sleep, I took him in my arms and set out walking once more. I felt deeply moved, and stirred. It seemed to me that I was carrying a very fragile treasure. It seemed to me, even, that there was nothing more fragile on all Earth. In the moonlight I looked at his pale forehead, his closed eyes, his locks of hair that trembled in the wind, and I said to myself:

"What I see here is nothing but a shell. What is most

important is invisible..."

As his lips opened slightly with the suspicion of a half-smile, I said to myself, again: "What moves me so deeply, about this little prince who is sleeping here, is his loyalty to a flower—the image of a rose that shines through his whole being like the flame of a lamp, even when he is asleep..." And I felt him to be more fragile still. I felt the need of protecting him, as if he himself were a flame that might be extinguished by a little puff of wind...

And, as I walked on so, I found the well, at daybreak.

XXV

"Men," said the little prince, "set out on their way in express trains, but they do not know what they are looking for. Then they rush about, and get excited, and turn round and round..."

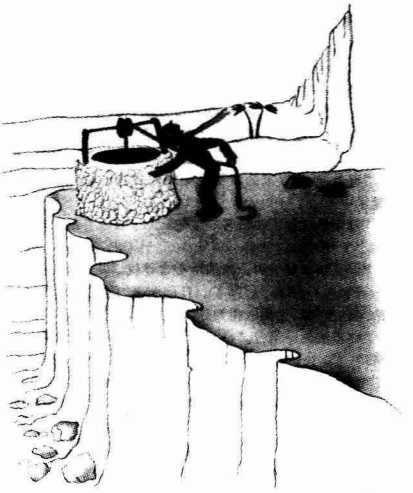
And he added:

"It is not worth the trouble..."

The well that we had come to was not like the wells of the Sahara. The wells of the Sahara are mere holes dug in the sand. This one was like a well in a village. But there was no village here, and I thought I must be dreaming...

"It is strange," I said to the little prince. "Everything is ready for use: the pulley, the bucket, the rope..." He laughed, touched the rope, and set the pulley to working. And the pulley moaned, like an old weathervane which the wind has long since forgotten.

"Do you hear?" said the little prince. "We have wakened the



well, and it is singing..."

I did not want him to tire himself with the rope.

"Leave it to me," I said. "It is too heavy for you."

I hoisted the bucket slowly to the edge of the well and set it there—happy, tired as I was, over my achievement. The song of the pulley was still in my ears, and I could see the sunlight shimmer in the still trembling water.

"I am thirsty for this water," said the little prince. "Give me some of it to drink..."

And I understood what he had been looking for.

I raised the bucket to his lips. He drank, his eyes closed. It was as sweet as some special festival treat. This water was indeed a different thing from ordinary nourishment. Its sweetness was

born of the walk under the stars, the song of the pulley, the effort of my arms. It was good for the heart, like a present. When I was a little boy, the lights of the Christmas tree, the music of the Midnight Mass, the tenderness of smiling faces, used to make up, so, the radiance of the gifts I received.

"The men where you live," said the little prince, "raise five thousand roses in the same garden—and they do not find in it what they are looking for."

"They do not find it," I replied.

"And yet what they are looking for could be found in one single rose, or in a little water."

"Yes, that is true," I said.

And the little prince added:

"But the eyes are blind. One must look with the heart..."

I had drunk the water. I breathed easily. At sunrise the sand is the color of honey. And that honey color was making me happy, too. What brought me, then, this sense of grief?

"You must keep your promise," said the little prince, softly, as he sat down beside me once more.

"What promise?"

"You know—a muzzle for my sheep... I am responsible for this flower..."

I took my rough drafts of drawings out of my pocket. The little prince looked them over, and laughed as he said:

"Your baobabs—they look a little like cabbages."

"Oh!"

I had been so proud of my baobabs!

"Your fox—his ears look a little like horns; and they are too long."

And he laughed again.

"You are not fair, little prince," I said. "I don't know how to draw anything except boa constrictors from the outside and boa constrictors from the inside."

"Oh, that will be all right," he said, "children understand."

So then I made a pencil sketch of a muzzle. And as I gave it to him my heart was torn.

"You have plans that I do not know about," I said.

But he did not answer me. He said to me, instead:

"You know—my descent to the Earth... Tomorrow will be its anniversary."

Then, after a silence, he went on:

"I came down very near here."

And he flushed.

And once again, without understanding why, I had a queer sense of sorrow. One question, however, occurred to me:

"Then it was not by chance that on the morning when I first met you—a week ago—you were strolling along like that, all alone, a thousand miles from any inhabited region? You were on the way back to the place where you landed?"

The little prince flushed again.

And I added, with some hesitancy:

"Perhaps it was because of the anniversary?"

The little prince flushed once more. He never answered questions—but when one flushes does that not mean "Yes"?

"Ah," I said to him, "I am a little frightened—"

But he interrupted me.

"Now you must work. You must return to your engine. I will be waiting for you here. Come back tomorrow evening..."

But I was not reassured. I remembered the fox. One runs the risk of weeping a little, if one lets himself be tamed...

XXVI

Beside the well there was the ruin of an old stone wall. When I came back from my work, the next evening, I saw from some distance away my little prince sitting on top of a wall, with his feet dangling. And I heard him say:

"Then you don't remember. This is not the exact spot."

Another voice must have answered him, for he replied to it:

"Yes, yes! It is the right day, but this is not the place."

I continued my walk toward the wall. At no time did I see or hear anyone. The little prince, however, replied once again:

"—Exactly. You will see where my track begins, in the sand. You have nothing to do but wait for me there. I shall be there tonight."

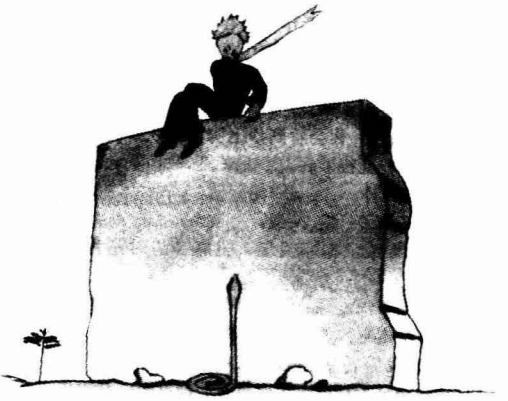
I was only twenty meters from the wall, and I still saw nothing.

After a silence the little prince spoke again:

"You have good poison? You are sure that it will not make me suffer too long?"

I stopped in my tracks, my heart torn asunder; but still I did not understand.

"Now go away," said the little prince. "I want to get down from the wall."



I dropped my eyes, then, to the foot of the wall—and I leaped into the air. There before me, facing the little prince, was one of those yellow snakes that take just thirty seconds to bring your life to an end. Even as I was digging into my pocket to get out my revolver I made a running step back. But, at the noise I made, the snake let himself flow easily across the sand like the dying spray of a fountain, and, in no apparent hurry, disappeared, with a light metallic sound, among the stones.

I reached the wall just in time to catch my little man in my arms; his face was white as snow.

"What does this mean?" I demanded. "Why are you talking with snakes?"

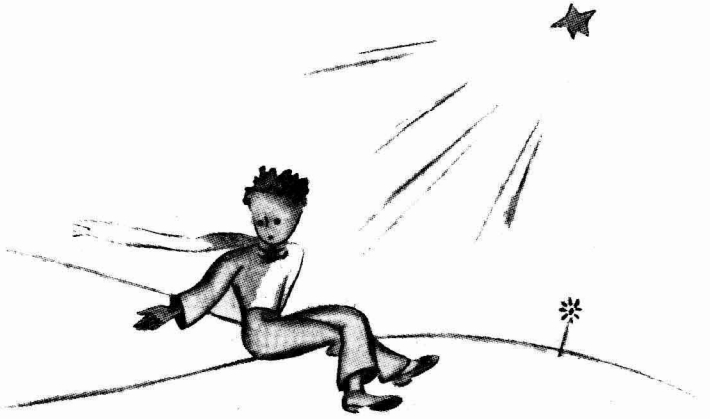
I had loosened the golden muffler that he always wore. I had moistened his temples, and had given him some water to drink. And now I did not dare ask him any more questions. He looked at me very gravely, and put his arms around my neck. I felt his heart beating like the heart of a dying bird, shot with someone's rifle...

"I am glad that you have found what was the matter with your engine," he said. "Now you can go back home—"

"How do you know about that?"

I was just coming to tell him that my work had been successful, beyond anything that I had dared to hope.

He made no answer to my question, but he added:



"I, too, am going back home today..."

Then, sadly—

"It is much farther... It is much more difficult..."

I realized clearly that something extraordinary was happening. I was holding him close in my arms as if he were a little child; and yet it seemed to me that he was rushing headlong toward an abyss from which I could do nothing to restrain him... His look was very serious, like some one lost far away.

"I have your sheep. And I have the sheep's box. And I have the muzzle..."

And he gave me a sad smile.

I waited a long time. I could see that he was reviving little by little.

"Dear little man," I said to him, "you are afraid..."

He was afraid, there was no doubt about that. But he laughed lightly.

"I shall be much more afraid this evening..."

Once again I felt myself frozen by the sense of something irreparable. And I knew that I could not bear the thought of never hearing that laughter any more. For me, it was like a spring of fresh water in the desert.

"Little man," I said, "I want to hear you laugh again."

But he said to me:

"Tonight, it will be a year... My star, then, can be found right above the place where I came to the Earth, a year ago..."

"Little man," I said, "tell me that it is only a bad dream—this affair of the snake, and the meeting-place, and the star..."

But he did not answer my plea. He said to me, instead:

"The thing that is important is the thing that is not seen..."

"Yes, I know..."

"It is just as it is with the flower. If you love a flower that lives on a star, it is sweet to look at the sky at night. All the stars are abloom with flowers..."

"Yes, I know..."

"It is just as it is with the water. Because of the pulley, and the rope, what you gave me to drink was like music. You remember—how good it was."

"Yes, I know..."

"And at night you will look up at the stars. Where I live everything is so small that I cannot show you where my star is to be found. It is better, like that. My star will just be one of the stars, for you. And so you will love to watch all the stars in the heavens... they will all be your friends. And, besides, I am going to make you a present..."

He laughed again.

"Ah, little prince, dear little prince! I love to hear that laughter!"

"That is my present. Just that. It will be as it was when we drank the water..."

"What are you trying to say?"

"All men have the stars," he answered, "but they are not the same things for different people. For some, who are travelers, the stars are guides. For others they are no more than little lights in the sky. For others, who are scholars, they are problems. For my businessman they were wealth. But all these stars are silent. You—you alone—will have the stars as no one else has them—"

"What are you trying to say?"

"In one of the stars I shall be living. In one of them I shall be laughing. And so it will be as if all the stars were laughing, when you look at the sky at night... You—only you—will have stars that can laugh!"

And he laughed again.

"And when your sorrow is comforted (time soothes all sorrows) you will be content that you have known me. You will always be my friend. You will want to laugh with me. And you will sometimes open your window, so, for that pleasure... And your friends will be properly astonished to see you laughing as you look up at the sky! Then you will say to them, 'Yes, the stars always make me laugh!' And they will think you are crazy. It will be a very shabby trick that I shall have played on you..."

And he laughed again.

"It will be as if, in place of the stars, I had given you a great number of little bells that knew how to laugh..."

And he laughed again. Then he quickly became serious:

"Tonight—you know... Do not come."

"I shall not leave you," I said.

"I shall look as if I were suffering. I shall look a little as if I were dying. It is like that. Do not come to see that. It is not worth the trouble..."

"I shall not leave you." But he was worried.

"I tell you—it is also because of the snake. He must not bite you. Snakes—they are malicious creatures. This one might bite you just for fun..."

"I shall not leave you."

But a thought came to reassure him:

"It is true that they have no more poison for a second bite."

That night I did not see him set out on his way. He got away from me without making a sound. When I succeeded in catching up with him he was walking along with a quick and resolute step. He said to me merely:

"Ah! You are there..."

And he took me by the hand. But he was still worrying.

"It was wrong of you to come. You will suffer. I shall look as if I were dead; and that will not be true..."

I said nothing.

"You understand... it is too far. I cannot carry this body with me. It is too heavy."

I said nothing.

"But it will be like an old abandoned shell. There is nothing sad about old shells..."

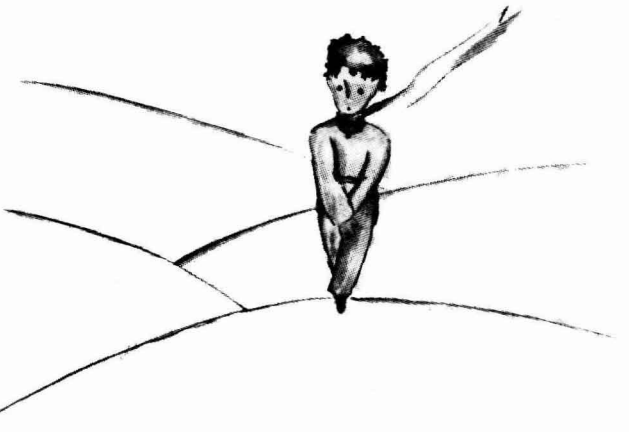
I said nothing.

He was a little discouraged. But he made one more effort:

"You know, it will be very nice. I, too, shall look at the stars. All the stars will be wells with a rusty pulley. All the stars will pour out fresh water for me to drink..."

I said nothing.

"That will be so amusing! You will have five hundred million little bells, and I shall have five hundred million springs of fresh water..."



And he too said nothing more, because he was crying...

"Here it is. Let me go on by myself."

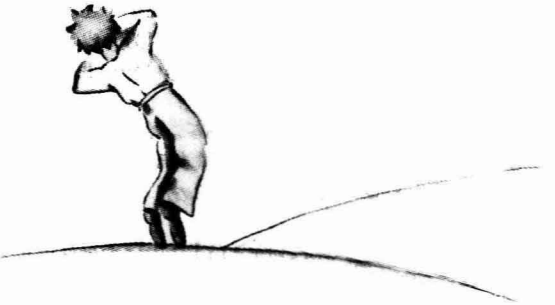
And he sat down, because he was afraid. Then he said, again: "You know—my flower... I am responsible for her. And she is so weak! She is so naive! She has four thorns, of no use at all, to

protect herself against all the world..."

I too sat down, because I was not able to stand up any longer. "There now—that is all..."

He still hesitated a little; then he got up. He took one step. I could not move.

There was nothing but a flash of yellow close to his ankle. He remained motionless for an instant. He did not cry out. He fell as gently as a tree falls. There was not even any sound, because of the sand.



XXVII

And now six years have already gone by... I have never yet told this story. The companions who met me on my return were well content to see me alive. I was sad, but I told them: "I am tired."

Now my sorrow is comforted a little. That is to say—not entirely. But I know that he did go back to his planet, because I did not find his body at daybreak. It was not such a heavy body... and at night I love to listen to the stars. It is like five hundred million little bells...

But there is one extraordinary thing... when I drew the muzzle for the little prince, I forgot to add the leather strap to it. He will never have been able to fasten it on his sheep. So now I keep wondering: what is happening on his planet? Perhaps the sheep has eaten the flower...

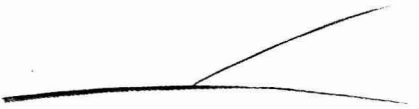
At one time I say to myself: "Surely not! The little prince shuts his flower under her glass globe every night, and he watches over his sheep very carefully..." Then I am happy. And there is sweetness in the laughter of all the stars.

But at another time I say to myself: "At some moment or other one is absent-minded, and that is enough! On some one evening he forgot the glass globe, or the sheep got out, without making any noise, in the night..." And then the little bells are changed to tears...

Here, then, is a great mystery. For you who also love the little prince, and for me, nothing in the universe can be the same if somewhere, we do not know where, a sheep that we never saw has—yes or no?—eaten a rose...

Look up at the sky. Ask yourselves: is it yes or no? Has the sheep eaten the flower? And you will see how everything changes...

And no grown-up will ever understand that this is a matter of so much importance!



This is, to me, the loveliest and saddest landscape in the world. It is the same as that on the preceding page, but I have drawn it again to impress it on your memory. It is here that the little prince appeared on Earth, and disappeared.

Look at it carefully so that you will be sure to recognize it in case you travel some day to the African desert. And, if you should come upon this spot, please do not hurry on. Wait for a time, exactly under the star. Then, if a little man appears who laughs, who has golden hair and who refuses to answer questions, you will know who he is. If this should happen, please comfort me. Send me word that he has come back.

THE LITTLE PRINCE

Antoine de Saint-Exupéry

我说《小王子》是一部天之作，说的完全是我自己的真心感觉，与文学专家们的评论无关。我甚至要说，它是一个奇迹。世上只有极少数作品，如此精美又如此质朴，如此深刻又如此平易近人，从内容到形式都几近于完美，却不落丝毫斧凿痕迹，宛若一块浑然天成的美玉。

——周国平

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